Under Winter Lights

By: A.J. Mac Iver



Table of Contents

Prologue 3
Winter Pages 5
Warm Cups 11
Quiet Hours 18
Between Shifts 23
Shared Space 29
Petals and Distance 35
Unspoken Things 42
Before The Rush 49
Lanterns On The Water 55
Warm Light 61
Impulse 68
Warmth After Heat 74
Something Real 83
In The Open 91
Pages We Don’t Show 100
Winter Times 108
Fun And Fans 117
Past Troubles 129
Drafts In December 140
The Eve Before 147
Beneath Familiar Ceilings 155
After The Lights Go Out 163
The Quiet After 168
Between Years 176
What We’re Becoming 184
Midnight 192

Prologue

The town always felt quieter in winter.
Not silent, just softened. The harbor carried the cold in gently, folding it through narrow streets lined with brick buildings and small storefronts. String lights hung year-round above the sidewalks, but in winter they mattered more. They glowed longer against early sunsets. Reflected off water that moved slowly, patiently, as if it too understood the season.
It was the kind of place where people learned to love quietly.

Where cafés filled with steam and low conversation became shelter from wind that crept under coats. Where flower shops stayed alive even when the trees stood bare. Where books were read by frosted windows and footsteps echoed sharper in the evening air.

Liz liked winter because it gave her an excuse to stay still.

She liked the way pages felt heavier in her hands when the world outside moved slower. She liked the steady rhythm of arranging flowers, the careful trimming of stems that would outlast the cold. She was not loud. Not rushing. She noticed things other people overlooked, the scent of salt under cinnamon, the way lantern light trembled on dark water, the difference between silence and loneliness.

Jayce on the other hand liked winter because it narrowed everything down.

Noise felt softer beneath snowfall. Crowds thinned. Conversations became smaller, more intentional. He watched people the way some watched the horizon, searching for stories in the tilt of a head or the pause between words. He worked behind a café counter, hands warm against ceramic cups, writing in margins when no one was looking.

They did not know yet that winter was drawing them toward each other.

That small routines would shift into shared glances.

That quiet people could still choose loudly.

This is not a story about grand gestures.

It is a story about staying.

About noticing.

About two people who almost miss each other, and then decide not to.

And it begins, like most things do, with cold air and warm light.



Winter Pages

The library was always warmer than it should have been.

Not just in temperature, but in the way sound softened once you stepped inside. The wind from the seaside city rattled windows and pushed cold air through every street, yet here everything felt still. Lights glowed softly above rows of books, and the air smelled faintly of paper and coffee someone had carried in earlier.

Elizabeth, Liz to almost everyone, sat at the same table she always chose near the tall windows. Her coat hung on the back of her chair, a scarf pooled beside her bag. A half-finished cup of tea sat near her elbow, forgotten again.

She barely noticed.

Her fingers rested lightly against the open page, eyes moving steadily as she read. The world faded when she reached this point in a story, where sounds blurred into background noise and time stopped mattering. Every so often her expression shifted, a small smile or quiet concentration, emotions that belonged more to the book than the room around her.

Across the library, chairs scraped softly. A group whispered and laughed before settling down.

Liz turned a page.

A few minutes later she noticed him.

Not because he was loud. He wasn't.

He moved like someone trying not to disturb anything, a notebook tucked under his arm and headphones hanging loosely around his neck. Dark hair slightly messy like he had run his hand through it too many times. He scanned the room for a seat, eyes lingering on empty tables before landing near her.

She watched for a second longer than she meant to.

He hesitated, then walked over.

“Hey,” he said quietly, stopping beside her table. “Mind if I sit here? Everywhere else is either full or loud.”

His voice was calm, almost careful.

Liz blinked, pulled gently from her book. “Oh. Yeah, that’s fine.”

He gave a small nod of thanks and slid into the chair across from her.
For a moment there was only the sound of chairs settling and pages turning. He opened his notebook, flipping past several filled pages covered in handwriting that looked rushed but neat enough to read. A pen tapped lightly against the paper as he stared at it, thinking.

Liz tried to return to her book.

She failed.

It wasn’t that he was distracting. It was more that he seemed focused in a way she recognized. The slight furrow in his brow, the way he paused before writing anything down. Like he was listening to something in his own head.

He started writing.

The scratch of pen on paper blended with the quiet sounds of the library. After a while it became almost calming.

Liz lowered her eyes back to her page, finally sinking into the story again.

Time passed without her noticing.

At some point she reached for her tea and found it cold. She made a soft face at the cup before setting it down again.

Across the table, the guy glanced up.

“Library tea,” he said under his breath. “Always a gamble.”

Liz laughed quietly, surprised by it. “I keep forgetting to drink it.”

“That’s how they get you,” he said. “Sell optimism, deliver disappointment.”

She smiled at that.

The tension that had quietly existed between strangers softened just a little.

He looked down at her book. “Good one?”

She glanced at the cover, then back at him. “Yeah. I keep rereading parts.”

“That’s usually a good sign,” he said, nodding like he understood.

He returned to his notebook, but not before she noticed a faint smile.

Liz hesitated, then asked softly, “Are you writing something?”

His pen paused.

“Trying to,” he said after a second. “Some days it works. Some days I just stare at the page and pretend.”

She nodded like that made perfect sense.

“I do that with reading sometimes,” she said. “Sit here for hours and realize I’ve read the same paragraph five times.”

He laughed quietly, genuine this time.

“Glad it’s not just me then.”

Silence settled again, but it felt different now. Easier. Familiar in a strange way.

Liz returned to her book, yet she found herself aware of small things she hadn't noticed before. The way he leaned forward when focused. How he paused to think before writing. The faint scent of coffee drifting from him.

Outside, wind brushed against the windows.

Inside, the world stayed still.

After a while, he closed his notebook and stretched slightly.

"I'm Jayce," he said, almost like he remembered introductions were a normal thing people did.

"Liz," she replied.

He nodded once. "Nice meeting you, Liz."

"Yeah," she said quietly. "You too."

He packed up slowly, slipping the notebook back under his arm. Before leaving, he glanced toward her book again.

"Hope the ending's worth it."

She smiled. "Me too."

He left as quietly as he had arrived.

The chair across from her sat empty again, but the space felt different now, like it held the echo of a conversation that had barely happened.

Liz looked down at her page, reading the same line twice before realizing she wasn't really paying attention anymore.

She glanced at the door he had gone through.

Then she turned the page and kept reading, though the library felt just a little less quiet than before.



Warm Cups

The café was already awake when Jayce arrived.

Not loud, not busy, just alive in that quiet way early mornings always were. The grinders hummed softly behind the counter, steam curled up from freshly pulled shots, and the air carried the familiar mix of coffee and baked bread. Outside, winter pressed its face against the windows, pale light reflecting off the sidewalk where students hurried past with hands shoved into coat pockets.

Jayce tied his apron and settled into motion.

There was comfort in repetition. Pull, steam, pour. Wipe the counter. Restock the cups. The rhythm gave his mind something to lean on while his thoughts drifted elsewhere. A half written sentence from the night before lingered in his head, unfinished and stubborn. He tried not to think about it too much.

Axel showed up ten minutes late, as usual.

“You look like you slept a solid three minutes,” Axel said, dropping his bag behind the counter.

Jayce glanced at him. “You look like you slept through your alarm.”

Axel grinned. “Correct.”

They worked side by side in comfortable silence for a while, the kind that only existed between people who had known each other long enough not to fill every gap with words. Customers trickled in, coats dripping with melted frost, voices still slow with sleep.

Jayce took orders and made drinks without thinking much about it.

Until she walked in.

He noticed the scarf first. Soft, neutral, wrapped loosely around her neck. Then the way she paused just inside the door, adjusting her grip on her bag, eyes scanning the menu even though it clearly was not the first time she had been there.

Liz.

The name came to him easily, surprising him.

She stepped up to the counter when it was her turn, cheeks slightly pink from the cold. She looked more awake than she had in the library, but there was the same calm about her, like she carried quiet with her wherever she went.

Jayce cleared his throat. “Hey.”

She looked up and her expression softened into recognition. “Hi.”

For a second, neither of them said anything else. It was not awkward, exactly. Just a pause that lingered a beat longer than necessary.

“What can I get you?” he asked.

She glanced at the menu, then back at him. “Uh. A latte. Oat milk, if that’s okay.”

“Yeah,” he said. “Of course.”

He rang it in, fingers moving on autopilot. When he looked up again, she was watching him, not in an obvious way. Just present.

“Library tea survivor,” he added lightly.

Her lips curved into a small smile. “I learned my lesson.”

He smiled back before he could stop himself.

“Name for the cup?” he asked.

“Liz.”

“Got it.”

He wrote it on the cup, careful with the letters, then passed it down the counter. She moved aside, hands tucked into the sleeves of her sweater, watching the process as he worked.

Jayce made her drink a little slower than usual. Not enough to be noticeable. Just enough to enjoy the routine.

When he set the latte down, steam rising gently, he slid it toward her. “Careful. It’s hot.”

“Thanks.”

Their fingers did not touch, but it felt close enough to matter.

Liz took her drink and hesitated, glancing around the café. There were empty tables scattered throughout, some near the windows, some closer to the back. After a moment, she chose one near the counter, close enough that she could still hear the sounds of coffee being made.

Jayce noticed.

He tried not to.

She settled into her seat, pulling a book from her bag and setting it beside her cup. She took a sip, sighed quietly in satisfaction, then opened the book like she had been waiting to do so all morning.

Jayce turned back to work, but his attention kept drifting.

The café filled gradually, the morning rush blooming and fading in waves. Jayce moved with practiced ease, greeting regulars, answering questions, handing off drinks. Every so often, he glanced toward Liz without meaning to.

She was reading.

Completely absorbed, just like before. Her shoulders relaxed as she leaned into the page, fingers resting along the edge of the book. Every now and then she paused, eyes unfocused for a second, then turned the page with quiet intention.

Her drink sat untouched for a while.

Jayce wiped down the counter and looked up just in time to catch her glancing at him.

She froze, caught.

So did he.

There was a moment where neither of them looked away. Not long. Just long enough to register surprise, then something softer.

Jayce lifted his hand in a small wave. Casual. Almost shy.

Liz blinked, then smiled and returned it, her fingers barely lifting from the table.

She went back to her book, but the corner of the page bent slightly where she held it, like she had not quite settled back in.

Jayce exhaled and focused on the espresso machine.

Axel leaned in close. “You gonna tell me why you’re smiling at the counter like that?”

Jayce shot him a look. “I’m not smiling.”

Axel raised an eyebrow and glanced toward Liz. “Sure.”

Jayce turned away before Axel could say anything else.

The morning slowed. The rush passed. The café grew quieter, filled with the low murmur of conversation and the soft clink of ceramic. Jayce wiped the counter again, even though it was already clean.

Liz was still there.

She shifted in her seat, tucking one leg beneath the other, eyes never leaving the page. Her latte was nearly gone now, foam clinging to the inside of the cup. Jayce noticed before she did.

On impulse, he made another one.

He carried it over himself this time, setting it gently on her table. “Refill.”

Liz looked up, startled. “Oh. You didn’t have to.”

He shrugged. “You looked busy.”

She smiled at that. “Thank you.”

He nodded once and stepped back, heart doing something inconvenient in his chest.

She took a sip, then returned to reading, but now she looked up more often. Not constantly. Just enough.

Jayce caught her watching him joke with a customer, caught the way her attention followed him when he moved. It felt strange to be noticed like that. Not uncomfortable. Just new.

When her phone buzzed, she checked it reluctantly, then closed her book with a soft sigh. She gathered her things slowly, slipping the book back into her bag like she was saying goodbye to it.

She stood and walked toward the door, then hesitated and turned back.

“Hey,” she said quietly.

Jayce looked up. “Yeah?”

“This was nice.”

He smiled. “Yeah. It was.”

She waved as she left, the door letting in a brief rush of cold air before closing again.

Jayce watched the spot where she had been sitting long after she was gone.

The café felt warmer than before.

He went back to work, hands steady, thoughts less crowded. Somewhere between pulling shots and wiping counters, a sentence finally settled into place in his head.

He thought he might write it down later.

Quiet Hours

Liz woke to the sound of wind brushing softly against her window.

For a few seconds she stayed still, wrapped in blankets, watching pale winter light creep across the ceiling. The room was cold in that gentle morning way where getting up felt like a negotiation. She pulled the blanket closer, letting herself drift between sleep and awareness.

Eventually she sighed and sat up.

The floor was cold under her feet. She reached for the sweater draped over her chair and slipped it on before walking to the small kitchen area of her apartment. The kettle clicked on, water slowly beginning to hum. Outside, the seaside city looked calm, streets still quiet except for the occasional car rolling past.

Mornings were her favorite. Nothing asked too much of her yet.

While her tea steeped, she opened the window slightly. Cold air slipped in, carrying the faint scent of salt from the ocean. She leaned against the counter and watched a few students crossing the street below.

Her mind wandered without direction.

Then, for a moment, she remembered the café.

The warm light. The steam rising from her cup. Jayce waving across the room like it was the most normal thing in the world.

She smiled faintly at the memory and shook her head at herself.

It had just been a nice morning.

Still, she wondered briefly if he worked early every day or if it depended on his schedule. The thought passed as quickly as it came.

She carried her tea to her small table and flipped open her planner. Work at the flower shop. Reading later. Maybe meeting Kira in the evening if she was free.

Ordinary things.

By the time she finished getting ready, the city had fully woken up. She wrapped her scarf around her neck and stepped outside. Wind tugged at her hair immediately, and she laughed under her breath, pulling her coat closer.

The walk to the flower shop was short but familiar. She passed the bakery, the bookstore, the corner where seagulls always seemed to gather. Winter made everything quieter, muted colors softened by the gray sky.

The bell above the shop door chimed when she stepped inside.

Warm air and the scent of fresh flowers welcomed her instantly. Buckets lined the walls, colors bright against the pale morning light. The owner waved from the back and Liz started her routine without needing direction.

Trim stems. Replace water. Rearrange displays.

She liked the quiet focus of it. Flowers demanded patience. You could not rush them.

As she arranged a cluster of white lilies, her thoughts drifted again.

She wondered if Jayce liked working in a café the way she liked working here. If he found comfort in repetition. If he noticed details the way she did.

She caught herself and smiled at her own wandering thoughts.

It was strange how easily someone could slip into your mind after only two conversations.

A customer interrupted her train of thought, asking for help choosing flowers. Liz helped them pick a small bouquet, explaining which blooms lasted longer in winter. The conversation grounded her again, bringing her back into the rhythm of the day.

Hours passed quietly.

When lunch came, she stepped outside with a small sandwich and sat on a bench near the waterfront. The wind was sharper now, making her cheeks sting slightly, but she liked the openness of the view. Waves moved lazily against the shoreline.

She pulled her book from her bag and read for a while, though her attention drifted more than usual.

At one point she caught herself thinking about the way Jayce had smiled when she said the café was nice.

She turned the page quickly, almost embarrassed even though no one was watching.

Afternoon slipped into evening.

The shop grew quieter as the sun lowered, golden light filtering through the windows. Liz cleaned up, sweeping fallen petals from the floor and closing up displays. By the time she finished, her hands smelled faintly of greenery and cold water.

Outside, the sky had already darkened.

She met Kira near campus, the two of them walking together through the chilly streets. They talked about classes, weekend plans, and small things that made them laugh. Conversation felt easy, familiar.

“You seem distracted today,” Kira said at one point, eyeing her gently.

Liz blinked. “Do I?”

“A little,” Kira said with a knowing smile. “Good distracted, though.”

Liz laughed softly and shook her head. “Just tired.”

Kira did not press.

They parted ways near the library, and Liz stood outside for a moment, looking at the lit windows. She considered going in, but kept walking instead. The thought of quiet reading at home felt better tonight.

Her apartment welcomed her with stillness. She changed into comfortable clothes, made another cup of tea, and curled up on the couch with her book.

The evening stretched out peacefully.

Every now and then, her thoughts wandered again.

She wondered if the café had been busy after she left yesterday. If Jayce had gone back to writing after his shift. If he always noticed when she looked up from her book.

The questions were soft, unimportant, like passing clouds.

She read until her eyes grew heavy.

Before bed, she set her book on the nightstand and turned off the lamp. Darkness settled around her, quiet and gentle.

As she lay there listening to the wind outside, one final thought drifted through her mind.

Maybe she would stop by the café again soon.

Not for any particular reason.

Just because it felt nice there.

She closed her eyes, and sleep came slowly, wrapped in the quiet warmth of ordinary days

Between Shifts

Jayce woke up to the sound of his alarm vibrating more than ringing.

He reached blindly for his phone, silencing it before it could fully drag him into the morning. For a moment he just lay there, staring at the ceiling, the room dim with early light. The air felt cold against his skin where the blanket had slipped, and he pulled it back up without thinking.

Mornings always came too fast.

Eventually he sat up, rubbing a hand over his face, hair sticking up in every direction. His apartment was quiet except for the faint hum of the heater struggling against winter. He moved through his routine half awake. Shower. Coffee. A piece of toast he barely tasted.

His notebook sat on the table where he had left it the night before.

He flipped it open while the coffee brewed, scanning the messy handwriting. Half finished scenes, fragments of dialogue, ideas that seemed better at two in the morning than they did now.

He added a line anyway.

Then scratched it out.

Outside the window, the city looked muted, gray sky stretching across the shoreline. People moved below wrapped in scarves and heavy coats, heads lowered against the wind.

Jayce checked the time and sighed.

Work.

The walk to campus woke him up more than the coffee did. Cold air burned his lungs, and he shoved his hands deeper into his pockets. The streets felt familiar, almost comforting in their routine. Same turns. Same storefronts. Same quiet morning rush.

He passed the flower shop without really thinking about it.

Then paused half a step after he passed.

He glanced back briefly at the windows filled with winter arrangements. He wondered if Liz was already inside, trimming stems or arranging flowers the way she seemed to move through everything calmly.

The thought surprised him.

He shook his head and kept walking.

The café smelled like warmth the moment he opened the door. Coffee, pastries, steam. The familiar noise settled him immediately.

Axel was already there, leaning against the counter with a drink in hand.

“You look like you’re thinking too hard,” Axel said.

“I just woke up,” Jayce replied.

“That’s never stopped you before.”

Jayce rolled his eyes and tied on his apron.

Work came quickly. Orders stacked up, machines hummed, voices blended into background noise. Jayce slipped into rhythm. Grind, pour, hand off drinks with practiced ease. He liked the simplicity of it, the way people came and went without requiring anything more than a smile and a name on a cup.

Between customers, his mind wandered.

He found himself glancing toward the door more often than usual.

He told himself it was habit. Watching for the next rush. Watching for regulars.

Still, when someone with a similar scarf walked in, he looked up faster than he meant to.

It wasn’t her.

He focused on the next order instead.

Around midmorning, the café slowed. Jayce wiped down the counter and leaned back slightly, stretching his shoulders. The quiet reminded him of the library, of turning pages and soft voices.

He thought about Liz sitting with her book, completely absorbed, like the world didn't matter for a while.

He wondered what she had been reading.

The thought lingered longer than it should have.

"Earth to Jayce," Axel said, snapping a towel lightly against the counter.

Jayce blinked. "What?"

"You spacing out again."

"Just tired."

Axel smirked but did not push.

The rest of the shift passed steadily. Students came in for late lunches. Someone spilled a drink. Someone laughed too loudly near the door. Life moved forward in small, ordinary moments.

Jayce cleaned the espresso machine and thought about writing later. Maybe tonight he would finally finish the scene he had been working on.

Maybe.

When his shift ended, he pulled off his apron and stepped outside. The cold hit instantly. He breathed in deeply, feeling the quiet after hours of noise.

Without really planning to, he walked toward the waterfront.

The ocean was restless today, waves tapping against the shore like a steady rhythm. He sat on a bench, hands wrapped around a takeaway cup he had brought with him.

People passed by in coats and scarves, conversations drifting in pieces. Jayce watched them without focusing on anyone.

He wondered briefly what Liz's day looked like outside the café. Whether she was reading somewhere warm or arranging flowers surrounded by color.

It felt strange, thinking about someone he barely knew.

He told himself it was nothing. Just curiosity.

Still, the thought returned more than once.

Eventually he stood and headed home.

His apartment greeted him with quiet. He dropped his keys on the counter and opened his notebook again, pen hovering over the page. Words came slowly at first.

Then easier.

He wrote about small moments. About warmth in cold places. About noticing someone without meaning to.

After a while he leaned back, rubbing his eyes.

The room felt still. Outside, wind rattled softly against the windows.

He wondered if she was reading right now.

The thought slipped in so casually he almost laughed at himself.

Jayce closed the notebook and stood, stretching. Dinner was something quick and forgettable. The evening passed quietly, music low in the background.

Before bed, he glanced at his phone, thumb hovering over nothing in particular. No messages he needed to answer. No plans tomorrow except another shift.

He turned off the light and lay down.

The day replayed in fragments. Coffee steam. Conversations. The sound of pages turning in his memory.

He wondered if she would come into the café again.

Not because he expected it.

Just because it had been nice.

The thought settled somewhere quiet in his chest as sleep slowly pulled him under, the city outside continuing its soft winter rhythm.

Shared Space

The café was busier than usual when Liz walked in.

Warm air wrapped around her instantly, carrying the familiar scent of espresso and baked bread. Outside, winter clung stubbornly to the streets, people rushing past with flushed cheeks and hunched shoulders. Inside, voices blended into a low hum, chairs scraped softly, and every table looked occupied.

She paused near the door, scanning the room.

Almost full.

She adjusted the strap of her bag and stepped into line anyway, letting the warmth sink into her slowly. From behind the counter, Jayce moved through orders with easy focus, sleeves rolled slightly, hands moving quickly between cups and machines. Every now and then he said something that made a customer laugh.

Liz found herself smiling before she realized it.

When it was her turn, he looked up and recognition softened his expression.

“Hey,” he said, like he had expected her to show up eventually.

“Hi,” she replied, pulling her scarf down. “Busy today.”

“Everyone decided they needed coffee at the same time,” he said. “What can I get you?”

She ordered her usual. He nodded like he already knew it.

While he made the drink, she glanced around again. No empty tables. A few students were spreading notebooks across entire surfaces, others leaning close in conversation.

Jayce slid her cup toward her. “Good luck finding a seat.”

She laughed softly. “Thanks.”

She took the cup and wandered toward the back, finally finding a small table with one open chair where someone had just packed up. She slipped into it quickly before anyone else noticed.

The noise faded once she opened her book.

Not completely, never completely in the café, but enough that she could settle into the page. Steam curled up from her coffee, warming her hands as she read. Every so often she glanced up absentmindedly, watching the flow of people.

She noticed Jayce moving behind the counter.

She told herself she wasn't watching him. Just looking up to rest her eyes.

Still, when he laughed at something Axel said, she noticed the way his shoulders relaxed.

Time passed quietly.

The rush began to thin. Customers drifted out, chairs emptied, and the energy of the café shifted into something calmer.

Liz turned a page, completely absorbed, when a shadow paused beside her table.

She looked up.

Jayce stood there holding his own cup, no apron now, hair slightly messy from working.

"Mind if I sit?" he asked.

Her surprise showed for only a moment. "Yeah. Of course."

He sat across from her, setting his drink down carefully.

For a second, neither of them spoke. The silence was not awkward exactly. Just new.

"I finally get a break," he said. "Thought I'd use it while the café is still quiet."

She nodded. "You looked busy."

"It's chaos until it isn't," he said with a small smile.

She closed her book gently, marking the page with a finger.

"What are you reading?" he asked.

She turned the cover slightly so he could see. “Just something I’ve read before.”

“You reread a lot?”

She smiled. “Yeah. I like knowing where things are going sometimes.”

He nodded like he understood that.

“I think writers call that cheating,” he said.

“Are you speaking professionally?” she asked lightly.

He laughed. “Not professionally. I barely count as a writer.”

“You write though.”

He shrugged. “I try to. Mostly ideas that don’t go anywhere.”

“That still counts.”

He studied her for a second, like he wasn’t used to someone saying that so easily.

“So,” he said after a sip of coffee, “what are you studying?”

“Literature,” she answered. “Mostly analysis and theory right now. Lots of reading. Lots of overthinking.”

He smiled. “Sounds exhausting.”

“It kind of is,” she admitted. “But I like it.”

“What about after college?” he asked.

She hesitated, thinking. “I’m not totally sure yet. Something with books maybe. Or something quiet.”

He nodded slowly. “Quiet sounds nice.”

“What about you?” she asked. “Besides making everyone’s mornings survivable.”

He glanced down at his cup. “I’m studying creative writing. Which sounds cooler than it actually is.”

“It sounds cool to me.”

He laughed softly. “Mostly deadlines and staring at a blinking cursor.”

She smiled. “That sounds familiar.”

They fell into an easy rhythm after that. Questions small enough not to feel intrusive.

Where they grew up.

Favorite spots near the water.

How winter felt different by the sea.

Jayce talked more than she expected, his voice relaxed now that he wasn’t behind the counter. He leaned back in his chair, hands wrapped around his cup like it was keeping him grounded.

Liz noticed he paused before answering anything too personal, like he measured his words carefully.

He asked about the flower shop when she mentioned work.

“You actually like it?” he said.

“I do,” she answered. “It’s calm. And flowers feel… honest.”

“Honest?”

She thought for a moment. “They don’t pretend to be anything else.”

He seemed to think about that, eyes distant for a second.

“That’s a good answer,” he said quietly.

She felt warmth rise to her cheeks and looked down at her cup.

Around them the café continued its steady rhythm. Someone laughed near the counter. A spoon clinked against ceramic. Music played softly overhead.

Jayce glanced at the clock and sighed. “Break’s almost over.”

“Oh,” she said, surprised by how quickly time had passed.

He stood, picking up his cup. “I’ll see you around?”

She nodded. “Yeah.”

He hesitated, then added, “I like talking with you.”

The words were simple, said casually, but they settled warmly between them.

“I like talking with you too,” she said softly.

He smiled, small but genuine, and headed back toward the counter.

Liz reopened her book, but the words blurred for a moment. She could hear him working again, moving through the familiar rhythm of the café.

And somehow the space felt different now.

Less like a place she visited.

More like somewhere she belonged, even just a little.

Petals and Distance

The bell above the flower shop door chimed softly when Jayce pushed it open.

He almost had not.

He had walked past once already, hands tucked into the pockets of his coat, telling himself he was just heading home. The cold breeze off the water bit at his ears, and he had nearly convinced himself that going inside would be strange. Unnecessary.

But he turned back.

The shop windows were fogged lightly from the warmth inside, little beads of condensation catching the soft gold glow of hanging lights. When he stepped in, the air changed instantly. It smelled like greenery and something faintly sweet. Earthy. Alive.

And there she was.

Liz stood behind the main counter, sleeves of her sweater pushed up slightly as she adjusted a bouquet in a tall glass vase. Her hair was pulled back loosely, a few strands falling forward as she leaned in, studying the arrangement with quiet focus.

She did not look up immediately.

Jayce watched her for a second longer than he meant to.

She moved carefully, like every stem mattered.

When she finally glanced toward the door, her expression shifted from concentration to surprise.

“Oh,” she said, a small smile forming. “Hi.”

“Hey,” he replied, suddenly aware of how unplanned this was.

“I didn’t expect to see you here.”

“Yeah. I, uh…” He glanced around at the walls lined with greenery. “I was walking by.”

Smooth.

Liz’s smile widened just a little, amused but gentle. “That’s usually how people end up here.”

He stepped closer to the counter. “It smells better than the café.”

She laughed softly. “That’s because we don’t burn espresso beans all day.”

He leaned his elbows against the wood counter. The shop felt different from anywhere he had seen her before. In the library, she was quiet and folded into her books. At the café, she was tucked into corners, watching the world from the edges.

Here, she looked certain.

“So,” she said, brushing her hands together lightly, “what brings you in?”

He hesitated, then decided on honesty. “I figured I should probably know something about flowers at some point in my life.”

She tilted her head. “That is very vague.”

“For research,” he added quickly.

“For writing?”

He nodded.

That made her expression shift again. Softer. Interested. “Okay. What kind of research?”

He glanced around at the buckets of stems and bundles tied with twine. “Do flowers actually mean things? Or is that just something people made up?”

Her eyes lit up in a way he had not seen before.

“They mean things,” she said immediately, stepping out from behind the counter. “Most of them do, anyway. It depends on the culture, but there’s symbolism behind a lot of them.”

She walked toward one of the wooden display tables, motioning for him to follow.

“This one,” she said, gently lifting a white bloom, “represents patience. And this one,” she gestured toward a small cluster of pale purple flowers, “means quiet admiration.”

Jayce watched her as she spoke. Her voice changed when she talked about this. It was steadier, more animated. She did not hesitate between thoughts. She touched each stem like it mattered.

“What about winter flowers?” he asked.

She glanced at him, surprised he had asked that specifically. “Winter blooms are my favorite.”

“Yeah?”

“They survive when everything else doesn’t,” she said softly. “They’re stubborn.”

He nodded slowly. “That sounds like something you’d write about.”

She looked at him for a second longer than usual, and something about the air between them shifted.

Before she could respond, the bell chimed again.

A girl about their age stepped inside, cheeks flushed from the cold. “Hey, Liz!”

Liz turned, smiling easily. “Hey, Mia. Picking up for your mom again?”

“Yeah, she forgot to call ahead, but she said you’d know what she likes.”

“I do,” Liz said, already moving toward the back counter.

Jayce stepped aside, hands in his pockets again, watching.

Liz moved with quiet confidence as she wrapped a bouquet in brown paper, chatting lightly with the girl about a class they apparently shared. She laughed once, the sound easy and unguarded.

Jayce felt something small and unfamiliar tighten in his chest.

Not jealousy.

Just awareness.

She had a whole rhythm here. A world that did not revolve around café tables and shared study breaks.

He realized he had only known pieces of her.

When the other girl left, the shop fell quiet again.

Liz returned to him, smoothing the paper scraps on the counter. “Sorry about that.”

“It’s fine,” he said. “You’re good at this.”

Her fingers paused. “You say that like you’re surprised.”

“I think I am,” he admitted.

She raised an eyebrow. “Why?”

He hesitated, then shrugged lightly. “You’re usually quiet.”

She considered that. “Quiet doesn’t mean I don’t have things to say.”

“I know,” he said quickly. “I just… I guess I’ve only seen you in places where you’re not in charge.”

Something flickered across her face. Not hurt. Just thoughtfulness.

“This place feels steady,” she said after a moment. “Flowers don’t argue. They don’t rush. They just… grow.”

He looked at the bouquet she had finished earlier. “That’s kind of comforting.”

“It is.”

Silence settled, but it wasn’t awkward. Just softer now.

She reached for a small bundle of pale blue stems. “Here. These are winter hardy. They last longer than most.”

He reached at the same time.

Their fingers brushed briefly.

Both of them stilled.

It lasted barely a second, but it felt longer.

Liz pulled her hand back first, tucking a loose strand of hair behind her ear. “Sorry.”

“It’s fine,” he said, though his voice had lowered slightly without meaning to.

She handed him the bundle more carefully this time.

He glanced down at them. “What do these mean?”

She hesitated.

“Endurance,” she said. “And sometimes… hope.”

He looked up at her.

For a second, neither of them spoke.

The warmth of the shop felt closer now. Thicker.

He cleared his throat. “I’ll take them.”

“For research?” she asked lightly.

“Sure,” he said. “Let’s call it that.”

She rang him up, fingers brushing the register keys softly. When she handed him the wrapped flowers, her smile was smaller this time. Not distant. Just thoughtful.

“Thanks for coming in,” she said.

“Yeah,” he replied. “I’m glad I did.”

The bell chimed again as he stepped back out into the cold.

The winter air hit his face sharply, grounding him. He looked down at the flowers in his hands, then back at the fogged shop window.

He had not meant to stay that long.

Inside, Liz stood still for a moment after the door closed. She watched his figure disappear down the street before turning back toward the counter.

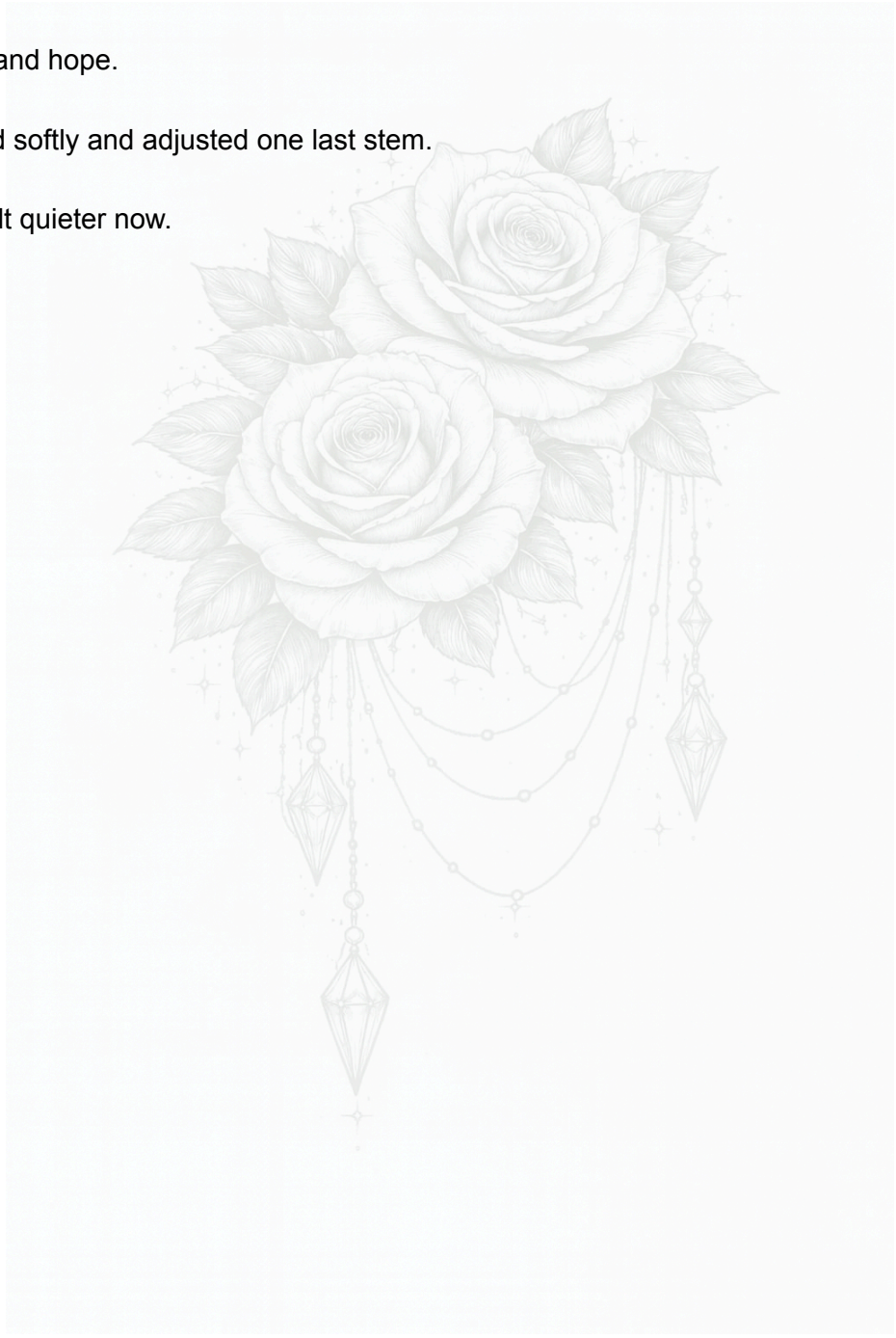
Her hands hovered over the vase she had been arranging earlier.

Endurance and hope.

She exhaled softly and adjusted one last stem.

The shop felt quieter now.

Different.



Unspoken Things

The café was louder than usual.

Liz noticed it before she even stepped fully inside. The low hum of conversation was layered with bursts of laughter, the sharp hiss of steaming milk, the constant shuffle of chairs scraping against the floor. Someone near the counter dropped a spoon, and it clattered loudly against tile.

She paused just inside the doorway.

This wasn't their usual quiet rhythm.

Jayce was behind the counter, sleeves pushed up, hair slightly messier than normal as he moved quickly between orders. He looked up instinctively when the bell above the door chimed.

Their eyes met.

For half a second, everything else blurred.

Then someone called his name.

"Jayce, I need that caramel latte!"

He blinked, snapped back into motion, but not before offering her a quick smile. "Hey!"

"Hey," she replied, stepping closer to the counter.

"Sorry, it's kind of insane today."

She glanced around at the packed tables. "I can see that."

"You still want the usual?"

She nodded. "Yeah."

"Give me a minute."

She moved toward her normal table by the window. It felt strange sitting there with the noise pressing in from all sides. She placed her book down, but instead of opening it immediately, she looked back toward the counter.

Jayce was moving constantly.

Taking orders. Passing cups. Laughing at something a customer said. Leaning slightly across the counter to hear someone over the noise.

He looked different like this.

Less reserved. More fluid. Like the chaos energized him.

Liz opened her book, but her eyes kept drifting upward.

He tucked a stray curl behind his ear with the back of his wrist. He smiled easily at a girl who lingered just a second longer than necessary after receiving her drink. The girl said something that made him laugh again.

Liz felt something small twist in her chest.

Not sharp.

Just unfamiliar.

She told herself it was nothing.

He talked to people all day.

That was his job.

Still, she turned a page she had not really read.

A few minutes later, Jayce appeared beside her table, placing her cup down gently.

“Survived the line,” he said.

“Barely,” she replied softly.

Their fingers almost brushed when she reached for the cup, but he pulled his hand back a little too quickly.

He seemed to notice it too.

“I’ll try to come sit when it slows down,” he added.

“Okay.”

He hesitated like he wanted to say something else.

“Jayce!” Axel’s voice cut through the air. “We’re out of lids!”

Jayce exhaled. “I’ll be back.”

Liz watched him disappear again.

The café swallowed him whole.

She tried reading.

She really did.

But every few seconds her attention shifted. She noticed the way he leaned down to help a shorter customer. The way he wiped the counter absentmindedly while listening to someone talk. The way he nodded with that quiet focus he usually reserved for conversations with her.

It felt strange seeing him shared.

At one point Axel approached her table instead, dropping into the chair across from her.

“You’re brave coming in on a day like this,” he said.

Liz blinked. “I didn’t know it would be this busy.”

“Campus winter festival prep,” he said. “Everyone’s wired.”

She nodded, glancing toward the counter again.

Jayce was watching.

Just for a second.

Axel followed her gaze and smirked slightly. “He’s been stressed all morning.”

“Yeah?”

“Won’t admit it.”

Liz smiled faintly. “He seems fine.”

“He always seems fine.”

There was something in the way Axel said it that lingered, but before she could respond, someone called him back.

Jayce finally made it over nearly twenty minutes later, dropping into the chair across from her with a tired exhale.

“Sorry,” he said again. “I feel like I’ve been running all day.”

“It’s okay.”

He leaned forward slightly. “You’ve been here a while.”

“I didn’t mind.”

He studied her face for a moment, like he was trying to figure something out.

“You’re quiet today,” he said.

She looked down at her cup. “It’s loud.”

He nodded slowly.

Another pause.

“I liked the flowers,” he added suddenly.

Her eyes lifted. “You did?”

“Yeah. They lasted longer than I expected.”

She smiled softly. “They’re stubborn.”

“Like you said.”

Their gaze held a second longer than it should have.

The noise of the café faded again, just at the edges.

Then a customer cleared their throat loudly near the counter.

Jayce leaned back with a sigh. “I’ve got to, ”

“It’s okay,” she interrupted gently.

He stood, lingering a moment like he didn’t want to move.

“I’ll come back.”

She nodded.

He didn’t.

The rush never really slowed.

When Liz finally checked the time, she realized she had stayed almost two hours. Jayce was still moving between orders, still caught in the current of voices and steam and clinking ceramic.

She gathered her things quietly.

For a second, she considered waiting.

Instead, she slipped her coat on.

As she walked toward the door, he looked up.

Their eyes met again.

She lifted her hand in a small wave.

He looked like he was about to step away from the counter.

Someone handed him a receipt.

By the time he looked back, she had already pushed open the door.

Cold air wrapped around her as she stepped outside.

It felt quieter out here.

Inside, Jayce stood still for half a beat longer than necessary, staring at the empty space near the window.

He should have gone over sooner.

He should have made time.

He didn’t know why it bothered him that she left without really talking.

It wasn’t like they had plans.

Still, when he glanced toward the table again and saw her untouched chair, something felt unfinished.

Outside, Liz walked slowly down the sidewalk, her book tucked against her chest.

She told herself it had just been a busy day.

Nothing more.

But as she passed the corner and the café disappeared behind her, she couldn’t shake the feeling that something small had slipped through her fingers.

Not lost.

Just… missed.

And somehow, that felt heavier than she expected.

Before The Rush

The café looked different in the morning.

Liz noticed that immediately.

The lights were dimmer, softened by pale winter sunlight filtering through the front windows. A few chairs were still stacked upside down on tables. The usual hum of conversation hadn't settled into the air yet. There was no hiss of steam, no rush of voices.

Just quiet.

For a moment, she stood outside the door, fingers curled tightly around the strap of her bag.

She could still leave.

It was earlier than she ever came. Earlier than she needed to.

The bell chimed when she pushed the door open.

Jayce looked up from behind the counter, a dish towel slung over his shoulder. His sleeves were rolled up, and his hair looked slightly damp like he had just run his hands through it.

He blinked in surprise.

"Liz?"

She almost said never mind.

Instead, she stepped inside fully. "Hi."

"You're early."

"Yeah." She gave a small shrug. "I thought I'd come before it gets loud."

Something about that made his expression soften.

"Good call," he said. "It's peaceful for about… twenty more minutes."

She smiled faintly and walked toward the counter.

He moved slower this time. No rushed motions. No orders stacked beside him. He picked up a cup and glanced at her.

“The usual?”

She nodded.

He began making it, and she found herself watching his hands. The way he measured the grounds carefully. The way he tapped the filter twice before setting it in place. Small habits she had never noticed when everything was loud.

“You didn’t have to come early,” he said gently.

“I know.”

The quiet stretched between them, but it wasn’t uncomfortable.

It was just aware.

He handed her the cup, their fingers brushing briefly this time. Neither of them pulled away too quickly.

“Yesterday was insane,” he said, leaning his forearms against the counter.

“It looked like it.”

“I meant to sit longer.”

Her eyes lifted. “You did?”

“Yeah.” He gave a small, almost sheepish smile. “I felt bad.”

“You don’t have to feel bad. It’s your job.”

“I know,” he said. “Still.”

She looked down at her cup, tracing the rim with her thumb.

“I stayed longer than I meant to,” she admitted quietly.

His gaze shifted slightly at that.

“Why?”

She hesitated.

Because I wanted to talk to you.

Because it feels different when you’re not there.

Because I didn’t like leaving like that.

Instead, she said, “I don’t know.”

He studied her face for a second, like he was trying to read the rest of the sentence she hadn’t finished.

The café felt smaller without the noise. Closer.

Liz felt her heartbeat climb for no good reason.

She adjusted the sleeve of her sweater.

“There’s… um.”

Her voice faltered.

Jayce straightened slightly. “Yeah?”

She stared at the steam rising from her coffee. “There’s a winter market thing by the harbor tonight. They’re lighting lanterns or something.”

He waited.

She swallowed. “I was thinking about going.”

Her fingers tightened around the cup.

“If you’re not working,” she added quickly. “You don’t have to. I just, I thought it might be nice.”

There it was.

Hanging gently between them.

Not a date.

Not labeled.

But clear.

Jayce didn’t laugh. He didn’t tease her.

He just looked at her.

Then he smiled, slow and warm and steady.

“I’m not working tonight.”

Her shoulders eased without her realizing they had been tense.

“I’d like that,” he said.

The words weren’t loud. They didn’t need to be.

She looked up at him then, fully.

“Okay,” she replied softly.

He glanced toward the clock on the wall. “What time?”

“Seven?”

“Seven works.”

Another quiet settled in, but it felt different now.

Lighter.

The bell above the door chimed again, breaking the moment. A couple of early customers stepped inside, shaking off the cold.

Jayce glanced toward the counter, then back at her.

“I should, ”

“Yeah,” she said, smiling.

She picked up her bag, standing slowly.

He stepped around the counter without thinking and walked her toward the door.

The morning air outside looked pale and sharp through the glass.

“Seven,” he repeated.

“Seven,” she echoed.

For a second, neither of them moved.

Then she pushed the door open.

Cold air slipped inside as she stepped out onto the sidewalk. She turned back once, lifting her hand in a small wave.

He waved back.

The door closed.

Jayce stood there a moment longer than necessary, staring at the spot where she had been.

He didn’t feel rushed now.

He didn’t feel unfinished.

He felt something else entirely.

Outside, Liz walked down the sidewalk with warmth blooming quietly in her chest.

She had almost not asked.

Almost let the morning pass like every other one.

But she hadn’t.

And tonight, at seven, something was going to change.

Lanterns On The Water

The harbor looked like it had been dipped in gold.

Liz stood near the edge of the walkway, her hands tucked into the sleeves of her coat, watching lantern light ripple across the dark water. Strings of warm bulbs stretched between wooden posts, swaying gently in the cold evening air. Somewhere behind her, music drifted softly from a speaker near one of the vendor stalls. The scent of cinnamon and roasted nuts lingered between passing groups of students.

Her breath fogged in front of her.

She checked the time on her phone even though she had arrived early on purpose.

Seven on the dot.

She told herself she wasn't nervous.

The crunch of footsteps on gravel made her look up.

Jayce was weaving through the small crowd, hands in the pockets of his coat, shoulders slightly hunched against the cold. When he spotted her, his expression shifted into that quiet smile she was starting to recognize as hers.

"Hey," he said when he reached her.

"Hey."

For a second, they just stood there, the glow of lantern light catching in the air between them.

"You didn't wait long, did you?" he asked.

"No," she lied gently.

He nodded once, glancing around at the lights reflecting on the water. "This is… nicer than I expected."

"It's calmer this year," she said. "I came once with Kira, but it was louder."

"I'm glad it's not loud."

“Me too.”

They began walking without deciding who started first.

The wooden boards beneath their feet creaked softly as they moved past vendor stalls. A couple stood nearby sharing a paper tray of pastries. A group of freshmen were laughing too loudly by the cider stand.

Jayce slowed slightly to match her pace.

The space between their arms was small. Not touching. Just aware.

“It smells like sugar and wood smoke,” he said.

“And salt,” she added, nodding toward the water.

He glanced at her. “You notice details like that.”

“You don’t?”

“I usually notice people.”

She didn’t know what to say to that, so she smiled faintly instead.

They stopped at a stall selling hot cider.

“I’ll get it,” he said before she could reach into her bag.

“You don’t have to.”

“I know.”

He handed her the cup once it was poured, his fingers brushing hers as he did. The warmth seeped instantly into her palms.

She took a careful sip and winced slightly at the heat.

He noticed.

“Too hot?”

“A little.”

He took the cup gently from her hands. “Give it a second.”

Their fingers lingered just a fraction longer than necessary when he returned it.

They resumed walking, closer now without realizing it.

A breeze swept in from the water, sharper than before. Liz instinctively rubbed her hands together after lowering the cup.

Jayce saw.

“Here,” he said, pulling one glove off and holding it out.

“You’ll be cold.”

“I’ll survive.”

She hesitated, then slid her hand into the offered glove. It was warm from him.

Their shoulders brushed as they walked again.

Neither of them moved away.

They found a quieter stretch of railing overlooking the harbor. Lanterns were being lowered onto the water now, tiny floating lights drifting slowly with the tide.

“It’s kind of unreal,” Liz said softly.

“Yeah.”

She leaned her forearms against the railing. He stood beside her, close enough that she could feel the warmth of him through their coats.

“I’m glad you asked me,” he said after a moment.

Her breath caught slightly. “I almost didn’t.”

“Why?”

She watched one lantern drift farther from the others. “I didn’t know if you’d want to.”

He looked at her then instead of the water.

“I wanted to.”

The honesty in his voice made her glance up.

For a second, the world narrowed to lantern light and the reflection of it in his eyes.

A burst of laughter exploded somewhere behind them. Someone bumped into Jayce’s shoulder, apologizing quickly before moving on.

The moment shifted.

They both straightened slightly.

A small, almost-smile passed between them.

They started walking again, slower this time. The crowd thinned as the evening wore on. Music softened. The lanterns grew smaller as they drifted out across the harbor.

Their hands brushed once.

Then again.

This time neither of them pulled away immediately.

They walked like that for a few quiet steps, fingers grazing, not quite intertwined.

Liz’s heart pounded louder than the music ever had.

Someone rushed past them, breaking the contact.

The space between their hands returned.

But it didn’t feel accidental anymore.

As they reached the end of the pier, the cold seemed sharper.

Jayce glanced toward her, studying her flushed cheeks. “Are you freezing?”

“A little.”

He looked toward the street beyond the harbor, then back at her.

“My place isn’t far from here,” he said carefully. “It’s warmer. I could make something. If you’re hungry.”

The offer settled between them.

Not rushed.

Not pressured.

Just simple.

Liz hesitated only a second before nodding.

“Okay.”

His expression shifted, relief mixed with something softer.

“Okay,” he repeated.

They turned away from the harbor together, leaving the lanterns drifting quietly behind them.

The glow of the market faded as they walked up the street side by side, their shoulders brushing again in the cold.

Neither of them said much.

But the silence felt different now.

Intentional.

And as they headed toward his apartment, the night felt like it was unfolding into something neither of them had quite planned, but both had quietly hoped for.

Warm Light

Jayce’s apartment was smaller than Liz expected.

Not cramped. Just lived-in.

A narrow hallway opened into a combined kitchen and living space, warm light spilling from a single floor lamp near the couch. A bookshelf leaned slightly against one wall, stacked unevenly with paperbacks and a few worn hardcovers. A blanket was draped over the arm of the couch like it had been left there without thinking.

“It’s not much,” he said, stepping aside to let her in.

“It’s nice,” she replied honestly.

It was warm.

That was the first thing she noticed. After the sharp harbor air, the heat wrapped around her shoulders and made her fingers sting slightly as they thawed.

He took her coat carefully, hanging it on a hook near the door.

“You can sit,” he said, gesturing toward one of the stools at the kitchen counter. “I’ll cook. I promise I won’t poison you.”

“That’s reassuring.”

He smiled.

The kitchen was small but organized. He moved with familiarity, pulling ingredients from the fridge and cupboards without hesitation.

“What are you making?” she asked, resting her elbows lightly on the counter.

“Pasta,” he said. “It’s hard to mess up.”

“Confident.”

“I’ve practiced.”

She watched him fill a pot with water and set it on the stove. The soft click of the burner and the low rush of flame filled the space between them.

For a moment, they were quiet.

Not awkward.

Just aware.

“You cook a lot?” she asked.

“Sometimes,” he replied, rinsing tomatoes in the sink. “It’s easier than going out.”

“Because it’s quieter?”

He glanced at her.

“Yeah.”

She smiled faintly. “I figured.”

He chopped slowly, deliberately. The rhythm of the knife against the cutting board was steady, calming.

“You always notice things,” he said after a moment.

“Like what?”

“Like when I don’t like loud places. Or when I’m tired.”

She shrugged lightly. “You’re not hard to read.”

He huffed a quiet laugh. “That’s slightly concerning.”

“It’s not a bad thing.”

He paused, leaning one hand against the counter. “What about you?”

“What about me?”

“You’re harder to read.”

She looked down at the countertop, tracing a faint scratch in the wood.

“I just don’t talk unless I’m sure I mean it.”

“That’s… kind of impressive.”

“Or inconvenient.”

“For who?”

She looked up then.

“For me,” she admitted softly.

The water began to boil, breaking the moment with a rolling sound. Jayce turned back to the stove, adding the pasta carefully.

Steam rose between them.

“Why inconvenient?” he asked.

She hesitated.

“Because sometimes I wait too long to say things.”

He didn’t push.

He stirred the sauce slowly instead, letting her fill the quiet if she wanted to.

After a second, she did.

“Like asking you tonight.”

His hand paused briefly over the pan.

“You were nervous,” he said gently.

“Yes.”

“Why?”

She laughed quietly, but there was no real humor in it. “Because I didn’t know if I’d imagined everything.”

“Imagined what?”

She felt her heartbeat quicken again.

“This,” she said vaguely, gesturing between them.

The kitchen suddenly felt smaller.

Jayce lowered the heat under the sauce, then turned to face her fully.

“You didn’t imagine it,” he said.

The words were steady.

Not dramatic.

Just certain.

Her breath caught slightly.

“I wasn’t sure,” she admitted.

“I was.”

The honesty in his voice made something in her chest loosen.

He stepped a little closer, not enough to crowd her, just enough that the space between them felt intentional.

“I don’t usually… invite people over,” he added.

She met his eyes. “I don’t usually say yes.”

A small smile tugged at his mouth.

“Then I’m glad you did.”

She nodded softly.

The sauce simmered behind him, the quiet bubbling sound grounding the room again.

He turned back to finish cooking, but the air had shifted. Warmer. Lighter.

“So,” he said after a moment, as if the conversation hadn’t just tilted everything slightly, “what made you like flowers?”

She smiled at that.

“My grandmother,” she said. “She used to grow them in this tiny backyard. Nothing fancy. Just stubborn little things that survived everything.”

“Stubborn,” he echoed.

“They never bloomed perfectly,” she continued. “But they always came back.”

He listened carefully as he plated the pasta.

“I think I like things that endure,” she added.

He set a bowl in front of her.

“That makes sense.”

They moved to the small table by the window.

Outside, the night had deepened. Streetlights cast long shadows across the pavement.

For a while, they ate quietly, the warmth of the food settling into the spaces the cold had left behind.

“This is really good,” she said after a few bites.

He looked almost embarrassed. “It’s just pasta.”

“It’s still good.”

He shrugged lightly. “I write better than I cook.”

She tilted her head. “You haven’t shown me enough writing to confirm that.”

He raised an eyebrow. “That sounds like a challenge.”

“Maybe it is.”

He leaned back in his chair slightly. “I might let you read something. Eventually.”

“I’ll hold you to that.”

They smiled at each other then.

Not shy.

Not tense.

Just comfortable.

The kind of comfortable that felt chosen.

When the conversation slowed, it didn’t feel unfinished like it had at the café days before. It felt full.

Outside, the world kept moving.

Inside, the apartment was quiet and warm.

And for the first time, neither of them felt like they were missing something unspoken between them.

Impulse

The night had grown quieter by the time Liz stood near Jayce's door again.

The dishes were washed. The kitchen lights were dimmed. Only the small lamp near the couch remained on, casting a soft amber glow across the room.

Neither of them had rushed the evening.

They had talked longer than either expected, about classes, about writing, about why she liked stubborn winter flowers and why he wrote in pen instead of pencil. The conversation had dipped and deepened naturally, without the sharp interruptions of a café rush or the cold bite of harbor wind.

Now, standing by the door, the warmth of the apartment felt heavier.

Real.

"I should go," Liz said softly.

"Yeah," Jayce replied, though he didn't sound entirely convinced.

He handed her coat to her, holding it open while she slipped her arms through. His fingers brushed lightly against her shoulders as he adjusted the collar.

The touch lingered.

She became acutely aware of everything, the quiet hum of the heater, the faint scent of tomato and basil still in the air, the way he was standing just a little too close.

"Tonight was…" she began, then faltered.

"Yeah," he said, smiling slightly. "It was."

Neither of them moved for a moment.

The distance between them felt thinner than it had all evening.

He walked her to the door anyway, even though it was only a few steps.

"Text me when you get back," he said, his hand resting lightly against the doorframe.

She nodded.

“Okay.”

She turned the handle.

Then paused.

Her heartbeat was loud in her ears.

She could leave now.

Walk back to her dorm.

Replay the night quietly like she usually replayed everything.

But something in her, something braver than usual, refused to let it end like that.

Before she could think better of it, she turned back toward him.

He barely had time to register the movement.

Her hand caught lightly at the front of his sweater as she leaned up and kissed him.

Not tentative.

Not questioning.

It was sudden and warm and real, weeks of almost-moments folding into one impulsive decision. Her other hand pressed lightly against his chest as if steadying herself, as if making sure he was actually there.

For a second, he froze in surprise.

Then he responded, one hand coming up instinctively to rest at her waist, grounding her, steady but certain.

The world narrowed.

No harbor noise.
No café rush.
No quiet overthinking.

Just warmth and breath and the realization that neither of them had imagined anything.

When she finally pulled back, her cheeks were flushed a deep, unmistakable red.

Her eyes widened slightly, like she had only just processed what she'd done.

"I, " she started, then stopped.

Jayce looked equally stunned, though a slow, almost disbelieving smile had started to form.

"I'll, I should go," she blurted, words tumbling over each other.

"Liz, "

But she had already opened the door.

Cold air rushed in as she stepped backward into the hallway.

"Goodnight," she said quickly, breathless.

Then she turned and hurried down the stairs before he could say anything else.

The walk back to her dorm felt twice as fast.

Her heart hadn't slowed.

Her fingers brushed her lips like she was checking whether it had actually happened.

What did I just do?

She replayed it in fragments.

The look on his face.
The way he'd pulled her closer.
The warmth of his hand at her waist.

"Oh my god," she whispered to herself as she reached the dorm building.

She pushed through the door, climbed the stairs too quickly, and fumbled slightly with her key when she reached her room.

Once inside, she shut the door and leaned back against it.

Her face felt like it was on fire.

She covered her mouth with both hands and let out a muffled, half-laugh, half-groan.

“I kissed him.”

The words felt unreal.

She paced once across the small room, then collapsed onto her bed, staring at the ceiling.

Had that been too much?
Too sudden?
Too obvious?

Her phone buzzed in her coat pocket.

Her stomach flipped.

She scrambled to grab it.

Jayce:
Did you just run away from me?

Her heart leapt into her throat.

Another message came through before she could type.

Not complaining. Just checking.

She buried her face into her pillow for a second, trying to contain the nervous, giddy energy surging through her.

Then she typed back carefully:

I may have panicked.

Three dots appeared almost immediately.

You don’t have to panic, he wrote.
I liked it.

Her stomach flipped again, softer this time.

Warmer.

She stared at the screen, smiling helplessly to herself.

Across town, Jayce was still standing near his door, hand resting absently where she had grabbed his sweater, replaying the exact same moment.

Neither of them would sleep easily that night.

And for once, neither of them wanted to.

Warmth After Heat

Liz told herself she wasn't nervous.

She had survived the kiss.
She had survived the texts afterward.
She had even survived sitting two rows behind him in class that morning while pretending to take notes and absolutely not staring at the back of his neck.

She was fine.

Totally fine.

And yet as she stood outside the café near closing, watching the warm glow of lights through the window, her stomach felt like it had wings.

Inside, Jayce wiped down the counter, laughing at something his coworker said. He looked tired in that quiet way he always did after long shifts, sleeves rolled up, apron dusted with flour.

Then he looked up.

And saw her.

His expression shifted instantly. The tiredness softened. His mouth curved slowly into something warmer, something meant only for her.

He finished up quickly, said his goodbyes, and stepped outside.

"You waiting long?" he asked.

"Maybe," she said, trying and failing to sound casual.

He studied her for half a second, then tilted his head slightly.

"Planning on running away again tonight?"

Her face immediately heated.

"I did not run."

"You absolutely ran."

She huffed. “I left with purpose.”

He laughed softly, the sound low and easy.

They started walking toward his apartment. The night air was crisp, but not cold enough to bite. Their shoulders brushed once. Twice.

The third time, neither of them moved away.

His hand hovered near hers for a few steps. Close enough to feel the warmth.

She noticed.

Before she could overthink it, she slid her fingers against his.

He looked down, surprised for half a second.

Then he laced their hands together.

Not tentative.

Not rushed.

Just… right.

They didn’t comment on it. They didn’t need to.

His apartment felt different this time.

Less intimidating. Less charged.

Or maybe the charge had simply shifted into something steadier.

“Alright,” Jayce said, shrugging off his jacket. “Redemption round. I promise not to ruin dinner.”

“You didn’t ruin dinner last time.”

“I absolutely could’ve.”

She followed him into the kitchen. “What are we making?”

“Something simple. Which means you’re not allowed to sabotage it.”

She gasped. “I am very helpful.”

“You taste everything.”

“That is quality control.”

He handed her a wooden spoon. “Then control this.”

The kitchen was small enough that they kept brushing into each other. When she reached for a spice, he reached for a pan at the same time.

Their hands collided.

They both paused.

There was a split second where they could’ve pulled away.

Instead, his fingers curled gently around hers.

He didn’t say anything. Just held her hand there, resting against the counter.

Her heartbeat stumbled.

“Jayce,” she murmured softly.

“Yeah?”

“You’re not cooking.”

“I’m multitasking.”

“You’re not.”

He smiled faintly, but didn’t let go.

Eventually she nudged him with her hip. “We’re going to burn something.”

“We won’t.”

They absolutely would.

A few minutes later she stood on her toes to reach a cabinet and he stepped behind her, reaching around her shoulder to grab a plate.

His chest brushed her back.

Her breath caught.

He didn’t move away.

Instead, he stayed there, one hand braced lightly on the counter beside her, the other still holding the plate he’d grabbed.

They stayed like that a second too long.

“Liz,” he said quietly.

She turned just enough to look at him.

They were very close.

Too close to ignore.

Her fingers curled into the fabric of his shirt.

“You’re distracted,” she whispered.

“So are you.”

She smiled.

And then she rested her forehead against his chest.

The moment softened instantly.

His arms wrapped around her waist without hesitation.

Comfortable.

Natural.

Like they'd done it a hundred times before.

Somewhere in the kitchen, something sizzled aggressively.

Neither of them noticed.

They talked like that, voices low.

About how weird class felt that morning.

About how she almost didn't kiss him.

"I was going to," he admitted.

She looked up at him. "You were not."

"I was," he insisted. "I just… lost my nerve."

She smiled shyly. "I almost did too."

"I'm really glad you didn't."

The air between them warmed again.

That's when the smell hit.

Both of them froze.

"…Do you smell that?" she asked slowly.

He turned his head toward the stove.

The pan was smoking.

"Oh no."

They rushed over, but it was far too late.

The food was undeniably, impressively ruined.

They stared at it.

Then at each other.

And burst out laughing.

Real laughter. Breathless and uncontrollable.

“You said we wouldn’t burn it!” she accused through giggles.

“I didn’t account for you being distracting.”

“Me?”

He pointed at her. “You.”

They gave up after that.

Twenty minutes later they were sitting on the floor by the couch, waiting for takeout to arrive. She had stolen his hoodie and curled her legs over his lap. His arm rested loosely around her shoulders, thumb brushing absent circles against her sleeve.

The apartment felt softer.

Quieter.

Safer.

“I didn’t want to run tonight,” she said suddenly, voice small but steady.

“I know,” he replied.

She looked up at him. “I was nervous.”

“You still are.”

“Maybe a little.”

He shifted so he was facing her more fully.

“You don’t have to be.”

“I know,” she said. “It’s just… new.”

“It’s new for me too.”

She searched his face for any trace of doubt.

She didn’t find any.

Just warmth.

His hand came up gently to brush a strand of hair behind her ear.

This time, when he leaned in, it wasn’t rushed.

It wasn’t impulsive.

It was slow.

Intentional.

He paused just enough to give her space to pull away.

She didn’t.

Their lips met softly.

No surprise. No urgency.

Just steady warmth and quiet certainty.

His hand rested at her waist. Hers slid up to his shoulder. The kiss deepened slightly, then slowed again, as if neither of them wanted to break it but neither felt the need to rush it either.

When they finally pulled back, their foreheads stayed touching.

She smiled first.

He exhaled quietly.

“That one,” she murmured, “I didn’t panic about.”

“Good,” he said softly.

A knock at the door startled them both.

They laughed again.

Dinner had officially been replaced.

He stood to grab the food, but she caught his hand before he moved too far.

He looked back at her.

She squeezed his fingers gently.

“Hey,” she said.

“Yeah?”

“I’m really glad I didn’t run.”

He smiled at her like she’d just handed him something fragile and important.

“Me too.”

And for the first time, nothing between them felt uncertain at all.

Something Real

The takeout containers were spread across the coffee table, lids flipped open, steam still curling faintly into the warm apartment air.

They had given up on plates.

Liz sat cross-legged on the floor with Jayce leaning back against the couch, one knee bent, the other stretched out under the table. She was tucked close enough that her shoulder rested against his chest without thinking about it.

It had already become natural.

He handed her a fork.

“Careful,” he said. “This one’s hot.”

She raised an eyebrow. “You’re saying that like you didn’t forget about an entire pan fifteen minutes ago.”

“That was a strategic pivot to takeout.”

“It was a disaster.”

“It was memorable.”

She laughed softly and took a bite.

For a while, they just ate and talked in that quiet, unforced way that had started to define them. About class readings. About the café crowd earlier. About how his coworker had tried to convince him that pineapple belonged on pizza and he had nearly walked out.

Her hand rested loosely on his knee while she talked, absentmindedly tracing little patterns in the fabric of his jeans.

He noticed.

His fingers drifted down, brushing over hers. He intertwined them casually, like it had always been this way.

There was no hesitation anymore when they touched.

The room felt warm. Not just physically. Steady. Safe.

At some point she leaned back more fully into him, resting against his chest as she finished the last of her noodles.

He adjusted automatically, wrapping an arm around her waist to keep her from sliding.

Neither of them commented on how easily they fit together.

When they finished eating, they didn't move to clean up right away.

The containers sat forgotten on the table.

She tilted her head back slightly to look up at him. "I think we cook better when we're not distracted."

He huffed quietly. "You are the distraction."

She gasped softly. "I am not."

"You absolutely are."

She narrowed her eyes playfully. "You're the one who wouldn't let go of my hand."

"That's because I like holding it."

The words landed softer than the teasing tone.

She felt it.

He did too.

The air shifted just slightly.

Not heavy.

Just aware.

He looked down at their hands, still intertwined. His thumb brushed over her knuckles, slower now.

“I keep almost calling you something,” he said quietly.

She stilled.

“What?”

He hesitated. Not because he didn’t know what to say. Because he wanted to say it right.

“I keep almost calling you my girlfriend.”

Her breath caught, just barely.

The room felt smaller in the best way.

“Oh,” she said softly.

He let out a faint, nervous exhale, like the words had been sitting in his chest all evening.

“I don’t want to just assume,” he continued. “I don’t want to label something without talking about it. But I also don’t want this to be vague.”

His arm tightened slightly around her waist, not possessive. Just grounding.

“I don’t want to say ‘this girl I’m seeing’ when I talk about you,” he added, a faint, self conscious smile tugging at his mouth. “It feels wrong.”

She turned fully in his arms so she was facing him now, knees brushing against his thigh.

Her expression wasn’t panicked.

It wasn’t overwhelmed.

It was soft.

“You’ve been thinking about that?” she asked.

“Yeah.”

“For how long?”

He gave a tiny shrug. “Since you ran away after kissing me.”

She covered her face with one hand. “Please stop bringing that up.”

He gently pulled her hand down.

“I liked that you were brave,” he said quietly. “And I liked that you stayed the next night. I just… I don’t want this to feel temporary.”

Her heart swelled in her chest.

It wasn’t dramatic.

It wasn’t a grand confession.

It was simple and steady and terrifying in the gentlest way.

He searched her face carefully.

“If you don’t want that,” he added quickly, “that’s okay. I just needed to say it.”

She reached for his hands this time, holding them deliberately.

“I don’t want it to be vague either,” she admitted.

His shoulders relaxed slightly.

“I keep wondering what I’m supposed to call you when my friends ask,” she continued, smiling shyly. “And I don’t like saying ‘this guy.’”

His lips curved.

“Yeah?”

“Yeah.”

There was a pause.

The kind that feels important.

He shifted closer, their knees pressing together.

“Liz,” he said softly, steady now. “Will you be my girlfriend?”

No dramatic build. No elaborate setup.

Just him. Looking at her like the answer mattered.

Her eyes warmed immediately. She felt it in her chest, in her throat, in that place that had been slowly untangling around him for weeks.

“You’re asking like I might say no,” she whispered.

“I’m asking because I don’t want to guess.”

She smiled then. Small at first. Then brighter.

“I want to be your girlfriend,” she said.

The words felt real as soon as they left her mouth.

Not rushed.

Not pressured.

Chosen.

He let out a breath he didn’t realize he’d been holding.

“Okay,” he murmured, almost to himself.

She laughed softly. “Okay?”

“Yeah.” His smile widened. “Okay.”

The simplicity of it made her chest ache in the best way.

He cupped her face gently, like she was something careful and important, and kissed her.

This kiss felt different from the last two.

The first had been impulsive.

The second had been intentional.

This one felt settled.

Certain.

His hand slid to her waist. Hers rested against his shoulder, fingers curling into the fabric of his shirt. They kissed slowly, without urgency, without nerves, just warmth and quiet happiness.

When they pulled apart, they stayed close.

Forehead to forehead.

She smiled again, unable to stop.

“So,” she said softly. “My boyfriend burned dinner.”

He groaned lightly. “Your boyfriend ordered excellent takeout.”

She laughed and leaned into him again, resting her head against his chest.

He wrapped both arms around her this time.

Not because he was afraid she’d run.

But because she wasn’t going to.

After a moment he pressed a small kiss into her hair.

“Hey,” he murmured.

“Yeah?”

“I really like calling you that.”

Her heart skipped.

“Your girlfriend?”

He nodded against her.

She smiled into his shirt.

“I like being it.”

And for the first time, there was no almost about it.

In The Open

Liz should have known better than to walk into her dorm common room wearing Jayce's hoodie.

It was navy. Slightly too big. The sleeves covered half her hands. And it definitely did not belong to her.

She had barely stepped inside before Hannah looked up from the couch.

"…Okay," Hannah said slowly.

Mia followed her gaze.

Then both of them looked at Liz.

"What?" Liz asked, already defensive.

Hannah sat up straighter. "You're glowing."

"I am not."

"You are," Mia agreed. "It's annoying."

Liz tried to walk past them casually.

Hannah grabbed her wrist and yanked her down onto the couch.

"That," Hannah said, tugging at the sleeve of the hoodie, "is not yours."

Liz looked down at it like she'd forgotten she was wearing it.

"It's just a hoodie."

"Whose."

Silence.

Mia gasped first.

"No."

Liz pressed her lips together, trying not to smile.

Hannah’s eyes widened. “No. No no no. You do not get to walk in here looking like that and not explain.”

Looking like what?

“Like someone who got kissed properly,” Mia clarified.

Liz buried her face in her hands.

“Oh my god.”

Hannah grabbed a pillow and smacked her lightly with it. “You have a boyfriend and didn’t tell us?”

Liz peeked out between her fingers.

“I have a boyfriend,” she admitted.

The words felt warm and new and still a little unreal.

Both of them screamed.

Actual screaming.

“Details,” Mia demanded immediately.

“When.”

“How.”

“Is he cute?”

“We’ve seen him, right?”

Liz laughed helplessly. “Yes, you’ve seen him. He works at the café.”

Hannah froze. “The tall one?”

“Yes.”

“The quiet one?”

“Yes.”

“The one who looks at you like you’re the only person in the room?”

Liz’s face turned bright red.

Mia pointed dramatically. “That one!”

Liz collapsed backward into the couch cushions. “Please stop.”

Hannah leaned forward, eyes sharp with curiosity. “When do we meet him?”

Liz hesitated.

That made them both narrow their eyes.

“You are not gatekeeping,” Mia warned.

“I’m not!” Liz said quickly. “He just… hasn’t met you yet.”

“Fix that.”

Two days later, Liz stood outside the café with her hands tucked into the sleeves of that same hoodie.

“Are you nervous?” Hannah whispered.

“No.”

“You’re fidgeting.”

“I am not.”

“You are,” Mia said calmly.

Inside, Jayce was wiping down tables. He glanced up toward the window.

And saw her.

His entire posture shifted.

He finished quickly, walked around the counter, and stepped outside.

“Hey,” he said, smiling softly at Liz first.

Not at the group.

At her.

She relaxed immediately.

“Hey.”

Then he looked at her friends.

His smile didn’t disappear, but it turned slightly more formal.

“Hi.”

Hannah stuck out her hand like this was a job interview. “Hannah.”

“Mia.”

“Jayce.”

He shook their hands politely. Calm. Steady. Maybe just slightly aware.

Liz noticed the way his shoulder brushed hers as he stood beside her.

Not accidental.

Grounding.

“So,” Hannah began lightly, “we’ve heard things.”

Liz made a strangled noise.

Jayce’s mouth twitched. “All good things, I hope.”

Mia tilted her head. “We’re still evaluating.”

Liz elbowed her.

He handled the teasing well. Answered questions without oversharing. Kept glancing at Liz like she was his anchor point in the conversation.

At one point, Hannah said casually, “So how long have you two been dating?”

Jayce didn’t hesitate.

“Not long.”

Not “seeing each other.”

Not vague.

Dating.

Liz felt it in her stomach.

Later, when they all went inside to grab drinks, he reached for her hand automatically as they stood in line.

He didn’t even look down.

Just threaded their fingers together like it was the most natural thing in the world.

Her friends noticed.

Hannah’s eyebrows shot up.

Mia gave her a very slow, knowing smile.

When Jayce stepped away to grab the drinks, Hannah leaned in close.

“He likes you.”

Liz tried to stay composed.

“I know.”

But the way she said it wasn’t defensive.

It was certain.

A few evenings later, Liz found herself back at the café near closing again.

Jayce was behind the counter with one of his coworkers, Sam, who had the kind of grin that suggested constant chaos.

Sam noticed Liz first.

“Oh,” he said loudly. “This must be her.”

Jayce closed his eyes briefly. “Don’t.”

Liz stepped closer, amused and slightly mortified.

Sam leaned across the counter. “We’ve heard about you.”

“You have not,” Jayce said quickly.

Sam ignored him. “The famous girlfriend.”

Liz froze.

Jayce did not correct him.

Instead, he came around the counter, walked straight up to her, and slid an arm gently around her waist.

“This is Liz,” he said simply.

Proud.

Easy.

No hesitation.

Something in her chest melted.

Sam gave an exaggerated nod. “Okay, I see it.”

Jayce shot him a look. “Go clean something.”

Sam laughed and disappeared into the back.

Liz looked up at Jayce once they were alone near the door.

“You talk about me?” she asked.

He shrugged lightly. “Sometimes.”

“What do you say?”

He tilted his head down toward her. “Enough.”

She smiled shyly.

When his shift ended, they walked back toward her dorm together.

The night air was cool, quiet.

“You did good,” she said softly.

“So did you.”

“My friends can be intense.”

“So can mine.”

She nudged him gently. “You didn’t let go of my hand.”

“I didn’t want to.”

The honesty in his voice made her chest ache again in that warm way.

They reached her dorm steps.

She turned to face him.

“It was weird,” she admitted. “Seeing you in my world.”

“Good weird?”

“Yeah.”

He nodded. “It felt the same.”

There was a small pause.

The kind that used to make her nervous.

Now it didn’t.

“You fit,” she said quietly.

He smiled. “You do too.”

She leaned up and kissed him softly.

Not urgent.

Just sure.

When she pulled back, he kept his hand at her waist for a second longer than necessary.

“Text me when you’re upstairs,” he said.

“I will.”

This time, when she walked inside, she didn’t feel split between two worlds.

They weren’t separate anymore.

They were just… shared.

And for the first time, being seen like that didn’t scare her at all.

Pages We Don't Show

The first snow of the season came quietly.

Not dramatic. Not heavy. Just enough to soften the edges of campus and dust the tops of parked cars like powdered sugar.

Liz stood on a chair in her dorm room, trying to hook a strand of cheap gold tinsel across the top of the window.

“It’s crooked,” Kira said from the bed.

“It’s charming,” Liz corrected.

“It’s tragic.”

Liz adjusted it slightly, then squinted.

“Better.”

Her room already looked warmer than usual. A small artificial tree sat on her desk, barely three feet tall, decorated with mismatched ornaments she’d collected over the years. Paper snowflakes were taped carefully to the walls. A string of warm white lights wrapped around her bookshelf.

She stepped down from the chair, brushing glitter from her hands.

“Are you decorating his place too?” Kira asked casually.

Liz tried not to smile too obviously. Failed.

“Maybe.”

Kira’s eyes narrowed knowingly. “Oh my god. You’re doing couple Christmas.”

Liz tossed a throw pillow at her.

Later that evening, Liz found herself in Jayce’s apartment with a tote bag full of decorations and his notebook tucked carefully beneath her arm.

He looked up from the couch when she walked in.

“What’s all that?”

“Holiday invasion,” she said.

He eyed the bag suspiciously. “Should I be afraid?”

“Yes.”

He stood and took the bag from her anyway.

They ended up rearranging his small living room slightly to make space for a tiny tree she insisted they needed. He protested at first.

“It’s barely December.”

“It’s winter.”

“That’s not the same thing.”

“It absolutely is.”

He gave in within five minutes.

They strung lights around the window. He held the ladder steady while she hooked them into place. At one point she almost lost her balance, and his hands instinctively went to her waist to steady her.

She looked down at him.

He didn’t let go immediately.

“Careful,” he murmured.

“You’ve got me,” she replied softly.

The words lingered longer than the moment required.

When the lights were finally plugged in, the room changed instantly. Warmer. Softer.

She stepped back to admire their work.

“It feels different,” she said.

“Good different?”

“Yeah.”

He looked around, then at her.

“It feels like someone lives here now.”

She smiled.

They sat on the floor afterward, backs against the couch, the small tree glowing faintly in the corner.

Liz reached into her bag and pulled out the notebook he’d given her earlier.

His posture shifted slightly.

“You didn’t have to bring it tonight,” he said.

“I know.”

She rested it in her lap but didn’t open it yet.

He rubbed the back of his neck, that familiar tell of nerves.

“I almost didn’t give it to you,” he admitted quietly.

She looked at him.

“I figured.”

He stared at the tree lights instead of her. “It’s easier when it’s just mine. If someone reads it, it becomes real. And if it’s real, it can be bad.”

She closed the small space between them, bumping her shoulder gently against his.

“I wasn’t going to read it without asking,” she reminded him softly.

“I know.”

Silence settled for a moment. Not uncomfortable. Just heavy with something honest.

“What made you start?” she asked after a while.

“Writing?”

She nodded.

He leaned his head back against the couch and thought about it.

“I was quiet growing up,” he said slowly. “Not in a mysterious way. Just… quieter than everyone else. Words were easier on paper. I could control them. Conversations felt messy. Writing didn’t.”

She listened carefully, not interrupting.

“It felt like building something,” he continued. “Like if I couldn’t say what I meant out loud, I could still shape it somewhere.”

“That makes sense,” she said.

He glanced at her. “What about you? Why books?”

She smiled faintly.

“They were quieter than the world too,” she admitted. “When I was little, I used to read under my blankets with a flashlight. I liked disappearing into someone else’s story. It felt safer than my own sometimes.”

He studied her more closely now.

“What kind of stories?”

“Anything where someone left,” she said without thinking. “Small towns. Big cities. Adventures. I liked the idea that you didn’t have to stay the same forever.”

He nodded slowly, like he understood more than she’d said.

“You still want to leave?” he asked gently.

She thought about it.

“Not in the same way,” she answered honestly.

The apartment felt softer as the night deepened. Snow continued falling outside, faint against the window.

She finally opened the notebook.

He didn’t stop her.

Her eyes moved slowly across the first page. She didn’t rush. Didn’t skim.

He watched her the entire time.

Not looking for critique.

Looking for reaction.

Her expression shifted gradually. Focused. Then thoughtful. Then something softer.

She closed it after a few pages and rested it against her chest.

“It feels like you,” she said quietly.

He blinked. “That’s not very specific.”

“It’s careful,” she clarified. “But it’s not afraid. It feels like someone who notices things other people don’t.”

He didn’t answer immediately.

“I don’t think you write because you’re scared,” she added gently. “I think you write because you feel everything.”

The words landed in the quiet space between them.

He swallowed lightly.

No joke. No deflection.

Just a small, stunned sort of stillness.

After a moment, he leaned forward and pressed a slow kiss to her forehead.

Not heated.

Not urgent.

Just full.

She leaned into him instinctively.

“Can I keep it?” she asked softly.

He hesitated.

Then nodded.

“Yeah.”

That was bigger than it sounded.

She closed the notebook carefully and set it beside her.

After a moment, she looked around the softly lit apartment again.

“You know,” he said thoughtfully, “when Christmas actually comes…”

She glanced at him. “Yeah?”

“We could celebrate with my family .”

She raised an eyebrow. “Not at your dorm?”

“It’s kind of bland to be honest and they have to meet you eventually.” He gestured around at the quiet lights and the small tree.

She considered that.

“You sure?” she asked.

He nodded. “If you want.”

She looked around his apartment again. At the lights they’d hung together. At the tree they’d argued about.

At him.

“Yeah,” she said finally. “Sure.”

Her smile was slow and bright.

“Okay,” he whispered.

They sat there a little longer, shoulders touching, watching the lights reflect faintly in the window.

It didn’t feel rushed.

It didn’t feel fragile.

It felt like building something.

And this time, neither of them was afraid to let it be real.

Winter Times

Liz knew something was up the second Jayce said, “So… I was thinking.”

They were walking across campus, the late afternoon sky fading into that soft winter blue that meant the air would bite soon. His hands were in his jacket pockets, shoulders slightly tense.

“That’s dangerous,” she said lightly, bumping her shoulder into his.

He huffed a quiet laugh, but it didn’t reach his eyes. He looked… focused.

“I haven’t actually taken you on a proper date yet.”

She slowed a step. “You’ve taken me on walks.”

“Walks aren’t dates.”

“You cooked for me.”

“I burned half of it.”

“That was charming,” she argued.

He stopped walking altogether.

Students passed around them, voices blending into the cold air, but for a second it felt like it was just the two of them standing in the middle of everything.

“Liz,” he said, more deliberate now, “will you go on an actual date with me?”

Her stomach flipped. Not because she didn’t expect it. Not because she didn’t want it. But because the way he asked felt intentional. Like he wasn’t assuming. Like he was choosing her again.

“Yes,” she answered immediately. Then, because her heart was suddenly pounding, she added, “Obviously. I mean… yes.”

A slow grin spread across his face, relief softening him.

“Good. Tomorrow night. There’s a winter market downtown. Lights, hot chocolate, the whole thing.”

Her eyes widened. “That sounds suspiciously like you’ve been planning this.”

“I might have googled ‘romantic winter date ideas’ at two in the morning,” he admitted.

She laughed, warmth spreading through her chest.

“Tomorrow night,” she repeated, and the words felt important.

Official.

Liz tried to act normal when she walked into the apartment later.

She lasted all of four seconds.

Hannah was on the couch, laptop open. Mia was at the kitchen counter, stirring something in a bowl.

Hannah looked up first. Her eyes narrowed immediately.

“What happened?”

“Nothing,” Liz said too quickly, toeing off her shoes.

Mia slowly turned around. “Why are you glowing?”

“I am not glowing.”

“You’re glowing,” Hannah confirmed.

Liz clutched her bag tighter, trying to hold it in. She made it three more seconds.

“He asked me on a date.”

Silence.

Then chaos.

Hannah shrieked and threw a pillow at her.

Mia dropped the spoon into the bowl with a loud clatter. “Official official?”

“Yes!”

All three of them screamed at once.

“What kind of date?”

“When?”

“What are you wearing?”

Liz blinked. “I don’t know.”

Hannah stood immediately. “We need options.”

“It’s tomorrow,” Liz said weakly.

“Exactly,” Mia replied, already marching toward Liz’s room.

Within minutes, her bed was covered in sweaters, jeans, skirts, boots, and at least three jackets she forgot she owned.

“Okay,” Hannah said, hands on hips, surveying the pile. “Winter market. Cute but casual. Effortless but not careless.”

Liz held up a sweater. “This?”

Mia squinted. “Too ‘I tried but I’m pretending I didn’t.’”

Liz threw it back on the bed.

She paced. “What if it’s awkward? What if we run out of things to say?”

Hannah turned slowly. “You two never run out of things to say.”

“That’s different. This is… official.”

Mia softened a little. “You’re nervous because you care.”

Liz exhaled. “It’s my first real date with him.”

Hannah’s expression gentled. She walked over and squeezed Liz’s shoulders. “He already looks at you like you’re the only person in the room. You could show up in a trash bag and he’d still stare.”

Liz laughed despite herself.

They settled on a soft cream sweater that hugged her just right, dark jeans, ankle boots, and a simple gold necklace. Hannah curled her hair slightly, just enough for texture. Mia insisted on a specific lip gloss that made her lips look warm instead of overly done.

When Liz finally stood in front of the mirror, she didn’t look like she was trying too hard.

She looked like herself.

“Okay,” Hannah said, nodding. “He’s going to lose it.”

Liz rolled her eyes, but her cheeks flushed.

The next evening, the air was crisp and smelled faintly like snow.

Liz spotted Jayce near the entrance of the winter market, hands shoved in his jacket pockets again, scanning the crowd.

He found her.

And froze.

It wasn’t exaggerated. It wasn’t dramatic. It was subtle, but unmistakable.

His mouth parted slightly.

She slowed her steps, suddenly hyper aware of herself. “You’re staring.”

“I know,” he said quietly.

He walked toward her like he’d forgotten where he was supposed to be.

“You look…” He stopped, shook his head once like he needed to reset. “Wow.”

Heat climbed up her neck. “It’s just a sweater.”

“Yeah. Sure,” he murmured, still looking at her like she’d stepped out of something unreal.

He reached up, adjusting the edge of her scarf where it had twisted slightly. His fingers lingered for a second longer than necessary.

“Hi,” she whispered.

“Hi.”

For a moment they just stood there, close enough that she could feel the warmth from him in the cold air.

Then he offered his arm.

She slipped hers through it.

The market glowed around them. Strings of lights stretched overhead, reflecting off patches of snow. Booths lined the street selling handmade crafts, pastries, and steaming drinks. Music played softly from somewhere further down.

They walked slowly, not rushing anywhere.

Jayce bought them hot chocolate from a stand, handing hers to her carefully. Their fingers brushed.

She took a sip and nearly burned her tongue.

He laughed. “Careful.”

“It attacked me.”

He shook his head, smiling, and instinctively reached for her free hand, warming her fingers between both of his.

They stopped at a booth selling knitted scarves, another with glass ornaments, then lingered near a fire pit where other couples stood talking.

“What did you think dating would feel like?” she asked suddenly.

He considered that. “Honestly? I thought it would be complicated. Like trying to impress someone constantly.”

“And?”

“And this just feels easy.”

Her chest tightened.

“I was nervous all day,” she admitted. “Hannah and Mia basically staged an intervention in my bedroom.”

He grinned. “Oh, I know they were involved.”

“How?”

“You look like you were professionally prepared.”

She swatted his arm lightly.

“I was nervous too,” he added more quietly.

“You were?”

“Yeah. I wanted it to be good. Not just… us hanging out. I wanted you to feel chosen.”

Her breath caught slightly at that.

“I do,” she said softly.

They moved toward the edge of the market where the lights were dimmer and the crowd thinner. Snow began to fall lightly, catching in her hair.

He brushed a few flakes away from her cheek.

“You’re freezing,” he said.

“I’m fine.”

“You’re not fine.”

He pulled her closer without hesitation this time, wrapping an arm around her. She leaned into him automatically.

They walked like that for a while, comfortable and close, their steps falling into the same rhythm.

As they neared her building later, the night quieter now, he cleared his throat slightly.

“So… the guys are having game night this weekend.”

She looked up at him. “Okay.”

“And they asked if you’d come.”

She slowed just a little.

“They did?”

He nodded. “They want to meet you properly. I may have talked about you.”

“For weeks?” she guessed.

He smirked. “Maybe.”

Her heart did something warm and steady.

“That’s a big step,” she said.

“I know.” He paused. “No pressure. Only if you want to.”

She thought about it. About stepping into his world the way he was already so comfortably stepping into hers.

“I’ll come,” she said finally.

The smile that spread across his face wasn’t relief.

It was pride.

“Yeah?”

“Yeah.”

They stopped in front of her building. Snow fell more steadily now, catching in the streetlights.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Then he leaned down and kissed her.

It wasn’t rushed. It wasn’t heated.

It was warm. Certain.

When they pulled back, his forehead rested lightly against hers.

“Good first official date?” he asked.

She smiled. “Very.”

She stepped back slowly, fingers slipping from his.

“Text me when you get inside,” he said.

“I will.”

She walked up the steps, heart full and steady, turning once before she went in. He was still standing there, watching her like he couldn’t quite believe she was real.

Inside, she leaned against the door, smiling to herself.

This didn’t feel like something fragile.

It felt like something building.

And she couldn’t wait for game night.

Fun And Fans

Liz stood outside Jayce's apartment door with a bowl of chips balanced in one hand and her nerves balanced in the other.

"You're fine," she muttered to herself.

The door swung open before she could knock.

Jayce.

He was in a hoodie, hair slightly messy like he'd been running his hands through it, and the second he saw her, his face lit up in that quiet way it always did.

"Hey," he said, stepping aside to let her in.

Inside was loud in a comfortable way. A coffee table covered in board games. Controllers tangled on the couch. Empty pizza boxes stacked like trophies.

Alex looked up first from where he was sprawled on the floor. "So this is the famous Liz."

Trainton, sitting cross legged with a deck of cards in his hand, grinned. "We've heard things."

"None of them are true," Jayce muttered.

Liz smiled politely, setting the bowl down. "I'm almost afraid to ask."

"You should be," Alex said.

Jayce's hand found the small of her back for just a second as he guided her further in. It was subtle. Natural. But grounding.

And then she noticed her.

A girl she hadn't seen before was sitting on the arm of the couch.

She was pretty in an effortless way. Dark hair pulled into a loose ponytail. Confident posture. Comfortable like she'd been here a hundred times.

The girl looked up and smiled warmly.

"Oh my god, you must be Liz."

Liz blinked. “Yes?”

The girl stood and stepped forward without hesitation.

“I’m Marie,” she said, offering a quick hug before Liz fully processed it. “Jayce’s old high school friend. I’ve known him since he was writing terrible fantasy novels in math class.”

Jayce groaned from behind Liz. “Please don’t start.”

Marie laughed easily and swatted his arm.

Liz smiled, but something in her chest shifted slightly.

Old high school friend.

“I’ve read everything he’s ever written,” Marie continued, brushing a strand of hair behind her ear. “Even the cringey stuff.”

“Especially the cringey stuff,” Alex added.

Jayce rolled his eyes. “Can we not do this in front of my girlfriend?”

Girlfriend.

The word helped.

Still, Liz noticed how naturally Marie stood close to him. How easily she reached out to bump his shoulder when she teased him.

It wasn’t dramatic.

It wasn’t obvious.

But it was familiar.

The games started. They split into teams for a chaotic round of a card game that involved too much bluffing and too much yelling.

Liz sat next to Jayce on the couch. Marie ended up on his other side.

At first it was fine.

Then, during one loud moment when Alex accused Trainton of cheating, Marie leaned forward to grab a card and her arm brushed along Jayce's.

It lingered just a second too long.

Liz noticed.

Jayce did too.

He shifted slightly away without making it obvious. Scooted just enough to create space.

Marie didn't react.

A little later, when she laughed at something he said, she placed a hand briefly on his forearm.

Again, subtle.

Again, normal on the surface.

Again, Jayce gently removed his arm under the excuse of reaching for a drink.

Liz told herself she was being ridiculous.

They were old friends.

People had history before her.

That was normal.

But the air felt different now. Tighter. Like something unsaid was hovering.

Jayce leaned closer to Liz during the next round, his knee pressing against hers intentionally.

"You okay?" he murmured low enough that only she could hear.

She hesitated.

"Yeah," she said, because she didn't want to be the jealous girlfriend.

He studied her face for a second longer than necessary.

Then, without saying anything else, he slid his arm around the back of the couch behind her, fingers resting lightly on her shoulder.

It wasn’t possessive.

It was grounding.

Marie noticed.

Her smile flickered for half a second before she focused back on the game.

The tension didn’t explode.

It just sat there quietly for a while.

Until Marie suddenly stood up mid game.

“I need a drink,” she announced, disappearing toward the kitchen.

A minute later, she reappeared in front of Liz.

“Hey,” Marie said softly. “Can I steal you for a second?”

Liz’s stomach dipped.

“Sure.”

They stepped just outside onto the small balcony. The cold air hit immediately.

Marie leaned against the railing, arms folded loosely.

“I just wanted to say something before this gets weird,” she began.

Liz stiffened slightly. “Weird?”

Marie gave her a knowing look. “You’re not subtle.”

Heat crept up Liz’s neck.

Marie sighed, but not unkindly.

“Jayce and I are close. We always have been. But not like that.”

Liz didn’t respond.

“He’s like my brother,” Marie continued. “We trauma bonded over bad teachers and worse haircuts. I read his drafts. I bullied him into publishing. I hype him up when he spirals.”

Liz blinked. “Publishing?”

Marie nodded casually. “Yeah. His old works are still getting purchased, by the way. I checked last week. People still love them.”

A thousand questions sparked in Liz’s mind.

He’d never mentioned publishing anything.

Marie smiled gently now.

“There’s nothing to fear from me. I promise. I just forget sometimes that new people don’t know the dynamic.”

Liz studied her for a long moment.

Marie didn’t look defensive.

She didn’t look competitive.

She looked… honest.

“Okay,” Liz said quietly.

Marie’s smile widened. “Good. Because you’re clearly good for him. He’s annoying, but he’s happier.”

Before Liz could respond, Marie nudged her shoulder lightly.

“Come on. They’re probably destroying the board without us.”

Back inside, the mood felt lighter.

Jayce looked up immediately when they walked in.

His eyes flicked between them.

Everything okay?

Liz gave him a small nod.

He relaxed visibly.

The games continued. Laughter filled the room again. Alex got dramatically eliminated. Trainton accused everyone of sabotage.

At one point, Marie leaned toward Jayce again but caught herself halfway and instead tossed a chip at him.

“Still can’t bluff,” she teased.

He smirked. “You’ve known that for ten years.”

Liz filed that away.

Ten years.

Later, when the night began winding down and pizza boxes were being collapsed and controllers unplugged, Marie clapped Jayce on the back.

“Seriously though,” she said. “Your old series? Still selling. Not huge numbers, but steady. People are finding it.”

Liz froze.

Series.

Old works.

Jayce rubbed the back of his neck. “Marie.”

“What? It’s impressive,” she insisted.

Liz looked at him.

“You’ve published something?”

His eyes met hers.

“Yeah,” he said quietly. “A while ago.”

“How much is ‘a while’?”

“High school. Early college.”

“And you didn’t think to mention that?”

He winced slightly.

“I didn’t think it mattered.”

Marie waved a hand dismissively. “It absolutely matters. He undersells himself constantly.”

Alex snorted. “He’s dramatic.”

Trainton nodded solemnly. “Very.”

Jayce shot them a look.

Liz watched him carefully.

There was no arrogance there. No secret ego.

Just… something guarded.

“I want to hear about it,” she said finally.

His expression softened.

“Okay,” he said. “You will.”

The night slowly dissolved after that.

Coats were grabbed. Goodbyes exchanged. Marie hugged Jayce quickly, then hugged Liz too.

“Text me if he’s annoying,” she whispered with a grin.

Liz surprised herself by laughing.

When the door finally closed and it was just them, the apartment felt quieter.

Jayce leaned against the door for a second.

“I’m sorry if that was weird.”

She hesitated.

“It was a little.”

He nodded. “I should’ve explained Marie better.”

“Yeah.”

He stepped closer, careful, deliberate.

“She’s family. But not like that. Never like that.”

Liz searched his face.

“I know,” she said slowly. “She told me.”

Relief crossed his features.

“But,” she added, “you have some explaining to do about this mysterious published author thing.”

He groaned softly. “I was hoping that would get ignored.”

“It will not.”

He smiled then. The tension fully gone now.

“Next date,” he said. “I’ll tell you everything.”

She tilted her head. “Everything?”

“Everything.”

She smiled back.

The weird feeling from earlier had faded into something else.

Curiosity.

As she grabbed her coat and he walked her to the door, she realized tonight hadn't shaken anything.

If anything, it had shown her something new.

There were parts of him she didn't know yet.

And she wanted to.

Game night had ended.

But something else had just begun.

Later that night, after Jayce had walked her home and she was curled up in bed staring at the ceiling, Liz picked up her phone.

She hesitated for a full thirty seconds.

Then she opened her messages.

Liz:
Okay. Be honest. On a scale of 1 to dramatic, how dramatic was he in high school?

The reply came almost instantly.

Marie:
Oh no.
You're ready.

Liz grinned.

Liz:
I want stories.

Three dots appeared.

Then disappeared.

Then appeared again.

Marie:
Call me.

Liz bit back a laugh and slipped her earbuds in before dialing.

Marie answered on the first ring.

“Okay,” Marie said immediately, no greeting needed. “Where do you want to start? The trench coat phase or the poetry phase?”

“The what phase?” Liz gasped.

Marie cackled.

“Oh, we are starting at the beginning.”

For the next hour, Liz lay on her stomach kicking her feet in the air as Marie spilled story after story.

Jayce dramatically announcing he was “misunderstood” at sixteen.

Jayce refusing to cut his hair because it “suited the protagonist aesthetic.”

Jayce getting into an argument with a substitute teacher about symbolism in a book neither of them had finished.

At one point Liz was laughing so hard she had to press her face into her pillow to keep from waking Hannah and Mia.

“He once tried to start a literary club,” Marie said through her own laughter, “and he was the only one who showed up for three weeks.”

Liz wiped tears from her eyes. “Stop, that’s actually kind of cute.”

“It was tragic and cute,” Marie corrected.

By the end of the call, the weird tension from earlier felt almost silly.

This wasn't rivalry.

This was history.

And Liz realized something as Marie finished another story about Jayce accidentally sending a love poem to the wrong group chat.

She wasn't threatened.

She was being let in.

"Thank you," Liz said softly once their laughter settled.

"For what?"

"For telling me."

Marie's voice warmed. "You're good for him. And now you have ammunition."

Liz grinned at the ceiling.

"Oh, I absolutely do."

They hung up still giggling.

Liz set her phone down, smiling to herself.

Jayce had a past.

It was awkward and dramatic and a little ridiculous.

And now, piece by piece, it was becoming hers to laugh about too.

Past Troubles

Liz was halfway through highlighting a paragraph she wasn't actually absorbing when her phone buzzed against her desk.

She glanced down, expecting something light.

A meme. A sarcastic comment. A dramatic complaint about coffee.

Instead, it was Jayce.

Jayce:
Can I come over later?

She frowned slightly.

No teasing.
No nickname.
No emoji.

Liz:
Of course. Everything okay?

Three dots appeared.

Disappeared.

Reappeared.

Then:

Jayce:
Yeah. Just… yeah. I'll explain.

Her stomach dipped.

He showed up an hour later.

No hoodie joke. No dramatic greeting.

Just a quiet knock.

Liz opened the door and immediately knew something was off.

He wasn't upset exactly.

But he was somewhere inside his own head.

“Hey,” she said softly.

“Hey.”

He stepped inside, ran a hand through his hair, then stood there like he wasn’t sure what to do with himself.

Liz closed the door carefully.

“What happened?”

Instead of answering, he pulled his phone out and held it toward her.

“Just read.”

She took it.

It was a screenshot of a forum thread.

A book discussion site.

The title read:

“Whatever Happened to J. Calder?”

Her eyebrows lifted.

Below it were comments.

> “This series deserved more attention.”
> “I reread it last month. It still holds up.”
> “Why did he disappear?”
> “There are still copies selling online.”
> “If you’re out there, please finish it.”

Liz scrolled slowly.

There were dozens of replies.

More than dozens.

People analyzing characters.

Quoting lines.

Arguing about theories.

Her chest tightened.

“You didn’t tell me they were still talking about it,” she said quietly.

Jayce let out a short breath. “I didn’t know.”

She looked at him.

He didn’t meet her eyes.

“You didn’t check?” she asked gently.

He hesitated.

That was answer enough.

Liz handed the phone back to him carefully, like it was fragile.

“How long has this been up?”

“Couple days,” he said. “Marie sent it to me this morning. It’s… picking up.”

He finally sat down on the edge of her bed, elbows on his knees.

“I thought it was done,” he admitted. “It was a high school thing. Early college. I moved on.”

“Did you?” she asked.

He gave her a look that wasn’t annoyed, just tired.

“I tried to.”

Liz sat beside him, leaving a small space between them.

“Why did you stop?” she asked softly.

He exhaled through his nose.

“Because it didn’t blow up. Because I thought if it wasn’t huge right away, that meant it wasn’t good enough. Because one guy online wrote a five paragraph review about how my pacing was garbage.”

Liz blinked. “You stopped because of one review?”

“It wasn’t just that.” His voice tightened slightly. “It’s easy to write when no one’s looking. It’s different when people are.”

She let that sit.

Outside, someone laughed in the hallway. A door slammed somewhere down the corridor.

Inside her room, everything felt still.

“Did you love writing it?” she asked.

He didn’t answer right away.

“Yes,” he said finally.

The word came out small.

“Then why are you pretending you didn’t?”

He looked at her then.

Really looked at her.

“Because what if that was it?” he said quietly. “What if that was the best I had in me? What if I go back and it’s worse?”

There it was.

Not ego.

Not indifference.

Fear.

Liz shifted closer, her knee brushing his.

“People are still reading it,” she said. “Years later. That’s not nothing.”

“It’s a handful of strangers online.”

“It’s people who felt something,” she corrected gently.

He rubbed a hand over his face.

“I stopped checking the sales numbers after a while. It felt pathetic. Like I was watching something slowly fade.”

“And now it hasn’t,” she said.

He gave a humorless half smile. “Apparently not.”

His phone buzzed again in his hand.

He glanced at it.

Rolled his eyes slightly.

“Marie?” Liz guessed.

“Marie,” he confirmed.

He handed her the phone again.

Marie:
IT’S TRENDING ON TWO DIFFERENT THREADS NOW.
Also your old publisher contact commented.
Call me immediately.

Liz looked up.

“Old publisher contact?”

Jayce grimaced. “It was a small indie press. Nothing huge. They helped me format and distribute. That’s it.”

“And they commented?”

“Apparently.”

Liz studied him.

“You could respond,” she said carefully.

He shook his head immediately. “No.”

“Why?”

“Because responding makes it real again.”

“And pretending it’s not real makes it go away?”

He didn’t answer.

She reached for his hand.

“You don’t have to decide anything tonight,” she said. “But don’t shrink just because it’s scary.”

He looked at her, something softening.

“I don’t want to be embarrassed again,” he admitted.

“You weren’t embarrassed,” she said firmly. “You were brave.”

He scoffed lightly. “Publishing at seventeen is brave?”

“Yes,” she said without hesitation. “Putting your work out where strangers can tear it apart is brave. Most people don’t do that at any age.”

Silence.

Then, quieter:

“You read it yet?” he asked.

“Not yet.”

“You should.”

“Are you warning me?”

“Maybe.”

She smiled faintly. “Is there a girl in it I should be worried about?”

He huffed a quiet laugh. “No.”

But something flickered there.

Interesting.

His phone buzzed again.

This time, it wasn't Marie.

He stared at the screen.

Liz watched his expression change.

"What?" she asked.

He swallowed.

"It's an email."

"From?"

He turned the screen toward her.

The subject line read:

Inquiry Regarding Continuation Rights – J. Calder Series

Her heart skipped.

"Jayce."

"I haven't opened it," he said quickly.

"You're going to, though."

He stared at the unopened message like it might explode.

For a long moment, neither of them spoke.

Then Liz squeezed his hand once.

"Whatever it says," she murmured, "you don't have to face it alone."

That did something to him.

She saw it.

The way his shoulders eased slightly.

The way his breathing steadied.

He looked at her, eyes clearer now.

“You’d really sit through me spiraling about fictional characters again?”

She smiled. “I already do.”

He laughed softly.

And then, slowly, he opened the email.

His eyes scanned.

Liz watched every micro expression.

Surprise.

Confusion.

Something like disbelief.

“Well?” she pressed.

“They’re asking if I’ve considered revisiting the series,” he said slowly. “They said there’s been consistent quiet sales and renewed discussion.”

Her chest filled with something bright.

“And?”

“And they want to talk.”

The words hung in the air between them.

This wasn’t just nostalgia.

This was opportunity.

He leaned back, staring at the ceiling.

“I didn’t expect this.”

“I don’t think you’re supposed to expect things like this,” she said.

He turned his head toward her.

“Are you scared?” she asked.

“Yes,” he admitted immediately.

“Good.”

He blinked. “Good?”

“Means you care.”

Silence stretched again.

Then he reached for her, pulling her gently into him until her shoulder rested against his chest.

“You make it hard to hide,” he murmured.

“Good,” she repeated softly.

They stayed like that for a while.

Not celebrating.

Not panicking.

Just breathing in the middle of something new.

Eventually, he shifted slightly, pulling his laptop from his bag.

Liz watched him carefully.

“What are you doing?” she asked.

He opened it slowly.

Clicked through folders.

Paused.

Then opened one labeled simply:

Drafts

An old document flickered onto the screen.

Untitled. Half finished.

He stared at it.

Then glanced at her.

“I don’t know what I’m doing yet,” he said quietly.

“You don’t have to,” she replied.

He looked back at the screen.

Fingers hovering over the keyboard.

And for the first time since he walked in, he looked less like someone cornered by his past.

And more like someone considering his future.

Liz leaned back on her hands, watching him.

Not pushing.

Not pulling.

Just there.

His cursor blinked.

Waiting.

So did the rest of his life.

Drafts In December

Liz had been meaning to start it for days.

She finally did on a Tuesday night while sitting cross legged on Jayce's bed, her back against the wall, his old paperback resting in her hands.

The cover was simple. Dark. Slightly dramatic.

J. Calder.

She glanced up at him across the room.

He was at his desk, laptop open, fingers hovering over the keyboard like the words might bite him.

"You're really going to read it right in front of me?" he asked without turning around.

"You opened a draft in front of me," she replied. "Fair is fair."

He huffed softly but didn't argue.

The room was warm, lit by a small lamp and faint Christmas lights strung along the window. Outside, snow gathered quietly on the ledge.

Liz turned the first page.

For a while, there was only the sound of keys tapping and pages flipping.

She expected it to feel awkward.

It didn't.

It felt strangely intimate.

She read the first chapter slowly, absorbing his tone. It was different from how he spoke. More controlled. More deliberate. There was weight in the way he described things.

"You wrote this at seventeen?" she asked, not looking up.

"Don't judge me."

"I'm not," she said softly. "It's good."

His typing paused for half a second.

Then resumed.

She kept reading.

The main character was sharp. Observant. A little guarded. A little dramatic.

She smiled.

That tracked.

Every so often, she glanced up.

Jayce was focused, brows slightly furrowed, occasionally deleting entire sentences before rewriting them.

“Are you stuck?” she asked gently.

“Always,” he replied.

She marked her place with her thumb and watched him for a second longer.

He didn’t look absorbed in a way that shut her out.

He looked present.

When she shifted to get more comfortable, he noticed immediately.

“You cold?”

“A little.”

Without missing a beat, he stood, grabbed a blanket from the chair, and draped it over her shoulders before sitting back down.

“Continue,” he said, nodding toward the book.

She smiled to herself.

Attentive.

Still him.

She dove back in.

By the fourth chapter, she was invested.

There was a female character introduced.

Strong. Stubborn. Quick with sarcasm.

Liz slowed slightly.

She wasn't exactly like her.

But there were similarities.

The way she challenged the main character.
The way she softened him without trying.

Liz glanced up again.

"You based her on someone?" she asked casually.

Jayce leaned back in his chair slowly.

"Every writer steals from real life," he said carefully.

"That's not an answer."

He studied her for a moment.

"Not one person," he admitted. "Pieces of people. Conversations. Moments."

She held his gaze for a second longer.

Then nodded.

That felt honest.

She returned to reading.

Across the room, he reopened his draft.

“Can I read something to you?” he asked suddenly.

Her head snapped up.

“From the new one?”

He nodded once.

She sat up straighter. “Yes.”

He turned the laptop slightly toward himself and read quietly.

The writing was different now.

More restrained.
More intentional.
Less trying to prove something.

When he finished, the room felt still.

“That’s beautiful,” she said honestly.

He looked almost embarrassed.

“It’s rough.”

“I like rough.”

He smirked slightly at that.

She closed her book gently, holding it against her chest.

“You’re better now,” she said softly.

He didn’t argue.

They sat in comfortable silence for a few minutes.

Then he glanced at his phone.

“Three days,” he said.

“Three days what?”

“Until Christmas.”

Her stomach fluttered slightly.

Right.

Christmas.

“At my place,” he reminded her gently. “My parents are excited.”

“Excited?” she repeated carefully.

“Marie may have told my mom about you.”

Liz dropped her head back against the wall. “Oh no.”

He laughed quietly.

“It’ll be fine. They’re not intense. Just loud.”

She eyed him suspiciously. “That’s not reassuring.”

He stood and crossed the room, sitting beside her this time instead of at his desk.

He took the book from her hands and placed it on the nightstand.

“You don’t have to be nervous,” he said. “You’re not an audition.”

“That’s easy for you to say.”

He tilted his head slightly. “You think I’m not nervous?”

She blinked. “Why would you be?”

“Because you matter,” he said simply. “And I want them to see what I see.”

That quieted her immediately.

He brushed his thumb lightly over her knuckles.

“I’m not disappearing into writing,” he added softly. “If I start getting weird about it, you tell me.”

“You’re not getting weird,” she said.

“Yet.”

She laughed.

He leaned forward, pressing a soft kiss to her forehead.

“You should keep reading,” he murmured. “There’s a twist in chapter eight.”

Her eyes widened. “There is not.”

“There is.”

She grabbed the book immediately.

He watched her with something fond and steady in his expression as she flipped pages quickly, determined.

Across the room, his laptop screen dimmed from inactivity.

He didn’t rush back to it.

For now, this was enough.

Snow continued falling outside the window.

Inside, between old pages and new drafts, something steady and warm kept building.

The Eve Before

Liz checked her reflection for the third time in the car window.

“You look the same as you did thirty seconds ago,” Jayce said from the driver’s seat, fighting a smile.

“That’s not helpful.”

“You look beautiful,” he corrected.

She exhaled slowly and turned toward him. “I’m not underdressed?”

“No.”

“Overdressed?”

“No.”

“Too quiet?”

He reached across the center console and took her hand.

“You are not a performance,” he said gently. “You’re just coming to Christmas.”

“Your family’s Christmas,” she corrected.

He squeezed her fingers once. “Yeah. My family’s Christmas.”

The neighborhood grew more decorated the deeper they drove into it. Twinkling lights wrapped around trees. Inflatable snowmen leaned dramatically on front lawns. One house had synchronized music playing faintly through speakers.

Liz’s stomach fluttered.

Three days ago, it had just been a reminder.

Now it was real.

Jayce turned down a quieter street lined with older homes, all warmly lit from within. He slowed in front of a two story house covered in soft white lights. A wreath hung on the door, and through the front windows she could see the glow of a Christmas tree.

“That’s it,” he said.

Liz stared at it.

It looked warm. Lived in. Loud, probably.

“You okay?” he asked.

She nodded. “Yeah.”

He studied her for a second longer.

Then he leaned over and kissed her cheek.

“They’re going to love you,” he said quietly.

She hoped he was right.

The second they stepped onto the porch, the front door swung open.

“Jayce!”

A woman with warm eyes and a flour covered apron rushed forward before he even knocked.

“Hi, Mom,” he laughed as she pulled him into a hug.

She held him tightly, then stepped back and immediately noticed Liz.

Her face lit up.

“And you must be Liz.”

Liz straightened slightly. “Hi, Mrs. Calder.”

“Oh no,” she said immediately, stepping forward and wrapping Liz in a hug before she could react. “Call me Diane.”

The hug was warm. Real. Not stiff.

Liz blinked in surprise before hugging back.

“We’ve heard so much about you,” Diane added, pulling away and giving her a quick once over, smiling approvingly.

Jayce groaned softly. “Mom.”

“What?” she said innocently. “I’m excited.”

A deeper voice called from inside.

“Are you going to let them in or interrogate them on the porch?”

Jayce’s dad appeared in the hallway, tall, glasses slightly crooked, holding what looked like a string of tangled lights.

“Dad,” Jayce said, stepping inside. “This is Liz.”

His dad smiled warmly. “Good to finally meet the girl who’s been distracting my son.”

Liz felt heat creep up her neck.

“I don’t—” Jayce started.

“We’re happy you’re here,” his dad finished kindly, stepping forward to shake her hand.

The house smelled like cinnamon and something baking.

The living room was cozy. A large tree stood in the corner, covered in mismatched ornaments. Stockings hung across the mantle, including one clearly handmade with Jayce’s name stitched slightly crooked.

Liz noticed that.

Of course he still had it.

“Coats here,” Diane said, already bustling toward the kitchen. “Dinner’s almost ready. Jayce, help your father. Liz, you can come keep me company.”

Jayce glanced at her, checking.

She nodded.

“I’ll survive,” she mouthed.

He smiled softly before disappearing down the hallway.

The kitchen was warm and loud and alive.

Diane moved between counters, stirring something on the stove while giving Liz a quick rundown of who would be arriving later.

“Marie might stop by tomorrow morning,” she added casually.

Liz smiled faintly. “I talked to her the other night.”

Diane’s eyebrows lifted. “Oh?”

“She gave me embarrassing high school stories.”

Diane laughed brightly. “Good. He deserves that.”

Liz relaxed more with every passing minute.

She helped set plates. She offered to chop vegetables. Diane insisted she didn’t have to but clearly appreciated it anyway.

“You make him calmer,” Diane said suddenly while placing rolls into a basket.

Liz blinked. “Calmer?”

“He used to carry the whole world in his head,” she said fondly. “Still does sometimes. But lately… he seems steadier.”

Liz swallowed gently.

“I think he steadies me too,” she admitted.

Diane smiled at that.

“That’s how it should be.”

Dinner was loud in the best way.

Jayce's dad told exaggerated stories about Jayce trying to build a "writing office" in the garage at sixteen.

"There was a candle involved," his dad said gravely.

"There was not," Jayce muttered.

"There absolutely was," his mother chimed in.

Liz laughed so hard she nearly spilled her drink.

Jayce glanced at her, half embarrassed, half amused.

"You're enjoying this too much," he said quietly.

"I am," she confirmed.

Under the table, his hand found hers.

It stayed there.

At one point, his mom asked casually, "So, Liz, have you read his books yet?"

Jayce froze.

Liz smiled sweetly. "I'm halfway through the first one."

"And?" his dad asked.

"It's really good," she said honestly.

Jayce relaxed slightly.

Diane beamed. "He never believes us when we say that."

Liz looked at him.

"I believe it," she said softly.

Something passed between them then. Quiet. Real.

Later that night, after dishes were done and Christmas music played faintly from the living room, they stood near the tree alone for a moment while his parents stepped outside to grab something from the car.

The lights reflected in the ornaments.

Liz traced one gently with her finger.

“You survived,” Jayce said softly.

“They’re wonderful,” she replied.

He watched her carefully.

“You fit here,” he said.

The words were simple.

But they landed deep.

She looked up at him.

“You were nervous,” she said.

“A little.”

“Why?”

He hesitated.

“Because bringing someone home for Christmas means something.”

Her heart tightened.

“Yeah,” she agreed.

He stepped closer, brushing a strand of hair away from her face.

“You’re not just visiting,” he added quietly. “You’re… here.”

She understood what he meant.

Not a fling.
Not temporary.

Here.

Footsteps approached from the hallway, laughter echoing.

The moment dissolved naturally.

But it lingered.

As the night wound down and she stood beside him watching his parents argue playfully over where to put extra wrapping paper, Liz felt something settle inside her.

This wasn’t just meeting family.

This was stepping into a piece of his history.

And somehow, it didn’t feel intimidating anymore.

It felt like being invited in.

Beneath Familiar Ceilings

The house had long since quieted.

Downstairs, the last of the laughter from board games and cocoa had faded into soft goodnights and the hum of the dishwasher. The Christmas tree lights still glowed in the living room, casting gold and red reflections against the windows. Outside, snow drifted lazily beneath the porch light.

Upstairs, Liz stood just inside Jayce's old bedroom, taking everything in.

It felt like stepping into a memory she had never lived.

The walls were still painted the same deep forest green his mother had mentioned he chose when he was thirteen. A few old posters hung crookedly near the closet door. Shelves lined one wall, crowded with trophies, paperbacks, dog eared notebooks, and framed photos of him at various awkward stages of life. There was something surreal about seeing proof of him before her.

Jayce stood in the doorway, rubbing the back of his neck.

"So," he said lightly, "we've got a situation."

Liz turned toward him, trying not to smile too hard at the sheepish look on his face.

"Let me guess," she said. "You didn't think this part through."

"In my defense," he replied, "I did not anticipate my mother inviting three extra relatives to stay over."

She laughed softly.

The bed was a twin. Comfortably a twin. Which meant there was no possible way both of them were sleeping there without someone losing circulation in their arm.

Jayce gestured toward the small couch pushed against the far wall. It looked like it had once been beige and now leaned toward a tired gray.

"I'll take the couch," he said immediately. "You take the bed."

Liz crossed her arms. "Jayce."

“No arguments.”

She walked over to the couch and pressed a hand against one of the cushions. It dipped dramatically. “You’re going to wake up in pain.”

“I’ll survive,” he said. “I used to fall asleep here writing in high school. It’s basically a memory foam mattress in my mind.”

She gave him a look.

He grinned.

There was something incredibly intimate about the moment, even though nothing was happening. The room felt smaller somehow. Warmer. It was different from the dorm, different from campus, different from the quiet corners of the library where they studied.

This was his beginning.

“You’re sure?” she asked more gently.

He nodded. “I want you comfortable.”

That did something to her heart.

Liz moved to sit on the edge of the bed, smoothing her hands over the quilt his mom had clearly laid out for them. “Okay,” she said softly. “But if you wake up sore, I’m telling your mom.”

He gasped. “You wouldn’t.”

She smiled. “I absolutely would.”

He laughed quietly, then stepped further into the room. He grabbed an extra blanket from the closet and tossed it onto the couch before pausing.

For a moment, neither of them moved.

It felt different being alone here.

Not because it was their first night under the same roof. They had studied late enough and fallen asleep near each other before. But this was his childhood space. His history pressed into every corner.

Liz glanced at the shelves again. “You kept a lot.”

Jayce followed her gaze. “Yeah. My mom refuses to turn it into a guest room. Says it keeps me from drifting too far.”

She stood and walked to one of the shelves, brushing her fingers along a row of old spiral notebooks. “Are these…”

“My early drafts,” he said. “The embarrassing ones.”

She turned slowly. “You still have them?”

“Unfortunately.”

Liz smiled. “I love that.”

He looked at her for a second, like he hadn’t expected that response.

“I used to sit right there,” he said, nodding toward the desk beneath the window, “and write until like two in the morning. Thought I was going to be some tortured literary genius.”

“You are a literary genius,” she said without hesitation.

He blinked.

She shrugged. “You’re writing a second book before we’ve even finished finals. That counts.”

A faint flush crept up his neck. He cleared his throat and picked up a pillow for the couch.

“Christmas is in the morning,” he said softly, like the thought had just landed on him.

“Technically,” she replied, glancing at her phone, “in about six hours.”

He exhaled, half excited, half exhausted.

Liz slipped beneath the covers, settling into the bed. It smelled faintly like clean linen and something warmer, something familiar. He turned off the overhead light, leaving only the glow from the small lamp on his desk.

Jayce sat down on the couch and tested the cushion. It squeaked.

Liz raised an eyebrow.

He glared at the couch. “It’s fine.”

She laughed quietly.

The room dimmed when he clicked off the lamp, leaving only the soft glow from the Christmas lights outside the window. Snow continued to fall, brushing against the glass.

For a while, neither of them spoke.

“You okay?” he asked finally.

“Yeah,” she said. “I’m just… happy.”

He shifted on the couch, propping his head against the armrest. “Me too.”

There was a small pause.

“Thank you,” she added.

“For what?”

“For letting me see this part of you.”

His voice softened. “You’re part of it now.”

Silence settled again, but it was comfortable.

“Goodnight, Liz.”

“Goodnight, Jayce.”

Morning arrived gently.

The house filled slowly with movement. Footsteps creaked on the stairs. The smell of cinnamon and coffee drifted upward. Someone laughed downstairs.

Liz woke first.

For a few seconds, she forgot where she was. Then she saw the green walls, the shelf of old notebooks, and the faint outline of Jayce curled on the couch.

Her heart squeezed.

He looked uncomfortable but peaceful, one arm tucked beneath his head, the blanket half sliding to the floor.

She sat up quietly and padded across the room to drape the blanket back over him.

His eyes opened instantly.

“You’re supposed to be asleep,” she whispered.

“You moved,” he murmured.

“You were cold.”

He blinked at her, then smiled in that soft, sleepy way that made her stomach flip.

“Merry Christmas,” he said.

“Merry Christmas.”

Downstairs, someone called Jayce’s name.

He groaned lightly. “They’re already up.”

Liz laughed.

They both got ready quickly, trying to smooth out hair and throw on sweaters before heading down.

The living room glowed brighter now. Presents were stacked beneath the tree. Jayce’s parents sat on the couch with mugs in hand. A few relatives lingered nearby.

Liz felt nerves flicker briefly, but Jayce reached for her hand and squeezed once.

It steadied her.

They joined everyone near the tree. Wrapping paper soon littered the floor. Laughter echoed. Someone turned on soft holiday music in the background.

Eventually, Jayce nudged a small box toward her.

It was wrapped simply in silver paper.

Her breath caught.

“You didn’t have to—”

“Just open it.”

She carefully peeled back the paper, revealing a small velvet box. Her hands trembled slightly as she opened it.

Inside lay a delicate silver necklace. At its center was a small sapphire, deep blue and catching the light from the tree.

Her eyes lifted to his.

“It reminded me of you,” he said quietly. “Calm. Strong. And way brighter than you realize.”

Her throat tightened.

He reached forward and lifted the necklace from the box. “Can I?”

She nodded.

His fingers brushed the back of her neck as he fastened it. The sapphire rested just below her collarbone, cool against her skin.

“It’s beautiful,” she whispered.

“So are you.”

She laughed softly through the emotion threatening to spill over.

“Okay,” she said, blinking rapidly. “Your turn.”

She handed him a rectangular package wrapped in deep brown paper.

He unwrapped it quickly.

Inside was a leather journal. Dark, smooth, the edges slightly worn in that intentional way that made it feel timeless. His name was embossed faintly along the bottom corner.

He stared at it for a long moment.

“Liz…”

“You’re always writing on loose paper or in half filled notebooks,” she said softly. “I thought maybe you deserved something that could hold everything.”

He ran his thumb over the cover like it was something fragile.

“This is perfect,” he said, voice low.

She smiled. “For your next book.”

He looked at her then, not joking, not teasing. Just looking.

“You’re my favorite chapter,” he said quietly.

Her cheeks warmed instantly.

His mom cleared her throat playfully from the couch, smiling at them over her mug.

The room filled again with laughter and movement, but something had shifted between them. Something steady and certain.

The sapphire caught the light as Liz leaned closer to him. The leather journal rested securely in his hands.

Christmas morning felt less like a holiday and more like a beginning.

After The Lights Go Out

The morning energy of Christmas slowly unraveled into something softer.

Wrapping paper lay in lazy piles near the tree, ribbons tangled around empty mugs and half eaten cookies. The house smelled like cinnamon and coffee and something warm that lingered even after breakfast was cleared away. Liz sat cross legged on the living room floor, absently twisting the sapphire necklace between her fingers as Jayce's mom gathered plates and hummed quietly to herself.

Jayce was nearby, leaning against the arm of the couch with the leather journal resting in his hands. He had opened it more than once already, flipping through the blank pages like he was measuring their weight. Liz caught him smiling down at it when he thought no one was looking.

She smiled too.

At some point, a photo album appeared.

Jayce groaned the moment his mom set it on the coffee table.

"No," he said immediately. "We talked about this."

"We absolutely did not," his mom replied cheerfully as she opened it. "Liz deserves to know who she's dating."

Liz leaned forward, curiosity sparkling. "Oh, I very much do."

The first photo was unmistakable. A younger Jayce stood in the middle of a school gym wearing a sweater two sizes too big, hair cut unevenly, smiling like he had just been told to say cheese without knowing why.

Liz covered her mouth. "Oh my god."

Jayce dropped his head back. "That was freshman year."

"That was a crime," she said, laughing. "They did you so wrong."

His mom flipped the page. "He insisted on that haircut."

"I was experimenting," Jayce muttered.

“With what,” Liz teased. “Poor life choices?”

He shot her a look that held no real heat, only fond resignation.

As the pages turned, Liz saw pieces of him she had never known. Soccer photos. Debate club. A candid shot of him asleep at his desk with a pen still in his hand. That one made her chest tighten in a way she could not quite explain.

The afternoon unfolded gently after that.

Liz found herself in the kitchen with Jayce’s mom, rolling cookie dough and listening to stories about holiday mishaps and childhood habits. Jayce appeared every so often, stealing cookie dough and earning playful scolding. At one point, Liz caught him watching her from the doorway, something quiet and full in his expression.

Later, while the house dipped into an afternoon lull, Jayce slipped upstairs. Liz noticed his absence and followed after a few minutes, padding quietly down the hall until she reached his old room.

The door was ajar.

He sat at the desk beneath the window, journal open, pen moving slowly across the page. The Christmas lights from outside cast faint reflections across the glass. He looked peaceful. Focused. Like this was exactly where he was meant to be.

Liz leaned against the doorframe, watching him for a moment longer than she intended.

He sensed her before he saw her.

He looked up, surprised, then smiled softly. “Hey.”

“Sorry,” she said. “I didn’t mean to interrupt.”

“You didn’t.” He closed the journal gently. “Just getting something down before it slipped away.”

She stepped into the room, glancing around again at the space that had shaped him. “Does it feel weird being back here?”

He thought for a moment. “Yeah. But in a good way. Like coming back to something familiar and realizing you’re not the same person anymore.”

She nodded. “I get that.”

They sat together on the edge of the bed for a while, shoulders touching, talking quietly about how different this Christmas felt from the ones before. How traditions changed. How people came and went. How sometimes the best moments were the unexpected ones.

Dinner that evening was simple and warm. Candles flickered between them as laughter filled the room again. Stories were shared. Mistakes confessed. Jayce admitted to once breaking a tree ornament and blaming it on the cat. Liz admitted she once wrapped empty boxes to make her gift pile look bigger.

When the dishes were cleared and the house finally settled into stillness, the Christmas tree remained lit, glowing softly in the corner of the living room.

Liz stood by the window, watching snow blanket the yard. Jayce joined her, close enough that she could feel the warmth from his arm.

“It’s really quiet,” she said.

“Yeah,” he replied. “It doesn’t happen often here.”

She turned toward him. “Do you want to go for a walk?”

He smiled, surprised. “You won’t freeze?”

She lifted her chin. “I’ll survive.”

They bundled up quietly and stepped outside, the cold immediately biting at their cheeks. Snow crunched beneath their boots as they walked down the quiet street, the moon hanging bright above them.

Their breath fogged the air as they laughed, huddling closer instinctively.

“Remember the first time we studied together,” Jayce said, “and I knocked over my coffee all over my notes.”

Liz groaned. “You tried to pretend it didn’t happen.”

“I absolutely did not.”

“You absolutely did,” she said, laughing. “You stared at it like it might evaporate.”

He shook his head. “Okay, but what about the time you sent me that voice memo.”

Her face warmed instantly. “We are not bringing that up.”

“You said my name so aggressively,” he teased.

“I thought I sent it to Hannah.”

They walked slowly, sharing memory after memory. The awkward starts. The near misses. The moments that had felt small at the time but now seemed to glow in hindsight.

“I didn’t realize we were making memories,” Jayce said quietly. “I just thought we were… existing.”

Liz smiled, slipping her hand into his. “Maybe that’s how the best ones happen.”

They stopped near the edge of the street where the snow lay untouched. The moonlight reflected off the ground, painting everything in silver. Jayce glanced at the sapphire resting against her collarbone, then back at her face.

“This is my favorite Christmas,” he said softly.

She met his gaze. “Mine too.”

They stood there for a moment, hand in hand, letting the cold and the quiet settle around them. Their footprints stretched behind them, leading back toward warmth and light.

Above them, the moon watched patiently as they turned back toward the house, still laughing, still talking, still adding to the growing list of moments they would one day look back on and smile.

The Quiet After

The house felt different the morning after Christmas.

Not empty. Just softer.

Sunlight filtered through the thin curtains of Jayce's old bedroom, pale and winter washed. The glow from the Christmas tree downstairs had finally been turned off, and in its absence, everything felt calmer. Still.

Liz stirred first.

For a few seconds she forgot where she was. Then she saw the deep green walls, the bookshelf stacked with old drafts, the familiar couch beneath the window.

Jayce was still asleep there, one arm draped over his eyes.

She smiled.

The room carried that quiet that only comes after something big. After laughter, after wrapping paper and late night cocoa, after the magic has settled into memory.

She sat up slowly, brushing hair from her face. The sapphire rested cool against her collarbone. She touched it absentmindedly, feeling its weight.

On the couch, Jayce shifted.

"You're staring," he murmured without moving his arm.

"I am not."

"You are," he said, voice rough with sleep.

She laughed softly. "You're on a terrible couch. I was checking to see if you survived."

He dropped his arm and squinted at her. "I did. Barely."

"Drama."

He pushed himself upright, wincing slightly as his back protested. "Okay, maybe not barely. But this thing is not supportive."

Liz scooted closer to the edge of the bed. “You could’ve taken the bed.”

“And given up the hero points?” he asked. “Never.”

She rolled her eyes, but there was warmth in it.

For a moment, neither of them moved. The air between them felt unhurried. No rush to get dressed. No presents waiting. No countdown to anything.

“It went by fast,” she said quietly.

“Yeah.”

He looked around the room like he was seeing it from a distance.

“I feel like we just got here,” she added.

He nodded slowly. “I know.”

There was something in his tone. Not sadness exactly. Just awareness. Like he understood how fragile moments could be.

Liz studied him. “You don’t want it to end.”

He gave a half smile. “I don’t want this version of it to end.”

She tilted her head. “This version?”

“Where everything’s simple,” he said. “Where I don’t have emails or deadlines or expectations. Where you’re just here.”

The honesty in it settled softly between them.

“I’m still here when there are emails,” she said gently.

“I know.”

But he didn’t look fully convinced.

They left the house mid morning, bundled in coats, promising Jayce's mom they would be back before lunch. Snow lined the sidewalks in neat, untouched layers. The town looked smaller in daylight. Quieter.

Liz walked close to him, their shoulders brushing as they made their way toward the little coffee shop at the corner of Main Street. It had fogged windows and a hand painted sign that read *Open* in looping script.

Inside, it smelled like roasted beans and cinnamon syrup.

They found a small table near the window. The kind where your knees almost touched even if you did not mean them to.

Liz wrapped her hands around her cup and watched him over the rim.

"What?" he asked.

She hesitated for just a second.

"Marie mentioned something at game night," she said. "About your old books still being purchased."

He stiffened slightly. Not defensively. Just subtly.

"Yeah," he said. "They are."

"You never really told me about them."

He looked down at his cup, turning it slowly between his palms.

"I wrote them in high school," he said. "Self published online at first. Then a small press picked one up."

Her eyes widened slightly. "Jayce."

"It wasn't huge," he said quickly. "It just… did well enough."

"Why did you stop?"

There it was.

The question lingered in the warm air between them.

He leaned back in his chair, exhaling slowly.

“Because it stopped being fun,” he said at first. Then he shook his head. “No. That’s not true. It stopped being simple.”

Liz stayed quiet.

“The first book got attention,” he continued. “People liked it. And that was great. Until it wasn’t.”

“Criticism?” she asked softly.

He nodded.

“At first it was small things. Reviews. Comments. Then it turned into expectations. What the second book needed to be. What I should improve. What I did wrong.” He gave a faint, humorless laugh. “You start reading enough of that and it gets loud.”

Liz could almost see it. Him younger. Reading every word. Taking it personally.

“I felt like I had to prove I wasn’t a fluke,” he said. “Like if the next thing wasn’t better, bigger, smarter, then maybe the first one was luck.”

She reached across the table but did not grab his hand. Just rested her fingers near his.

“So you stopped,” she said gently.

“I told myself I was focusing on school,” he admitted. “Which was partly true. But mostly I was scared.”

“Of failing?”

“Of confirming what the worst reviews said.”

The vulnerability in his voice was quiet but unmistakable.

Liz let the silence hold for a moment.

“You’re writing again,” she said.

“Yeah.”

“And it’s good.”

He looked at her carefully. “You’ve only read parts.”

“I know enough.”

He studied her expression like he was searching for doubt. He did not find it.

“You make it easier,” he said suddenly.

She blinked. “Me?”

“You don’t look at me like I’m supposed to be something. You just…” He searched for the word. “See me.”

Her chest tightened.

“I don’t want to be the thing that distracts you,” she said carefully. “From writing. From building what you want.”

“You’re not.”

“But I don’t want you to feel like you have to choose either,” she continued. “Your career or me.”

He leaned forward now, elbows on the table.

“That’s what scares me,” he admitted. “What if I get too wrapped up? What if I start chasing deadlines and forget to be present? What if I lose balance?”

Liz held his gaze.

“Then we talk,” she said. “And we fix it.”

He shook his head slightly, almost in disbelief at how simple she made it sound.

“I don’t want to be something you fit around your ambition,” she added. “I want to be part of your life. Not competing with it.”

Something shifted in his expression then. Not dramatic. Just steady.

“You are,” he said. “You already are.”

He reached across the table and finally took her hand.

“You make me feel steady,” he admitted. “Like I don’t have to outrun anything.”

Her thumb brushed over his knuckles.

“You don’t,” she said softly.

They stayed there longer than they meant to. Talking about writing. About fear. About what next year might look like. Not in grand plans. Just in small, grounded ways.

When they stepped back outside, the sky had turned pale gray. Snow crunched beneath their boots again.

They did not talk much on the walk back.

They did not need to.

When they reached the car, Jayce opened her door for her. As he rounded to his side, he caught her watching him.

“What?” he asked.

“Nothing,” she said. “Just thinking.”

“Dangerous.”

She smiled faintly.

As he started the car, she reached over and laced her fingers through his.

He squeezed once.

The drive back to the house was quiet. Not awkward. Not heavy.

Just aware.

Aware that something deeper had settled between them. That the warmth of Christmas had shifted into something steadier. Less sparkle. More foundation.

Outside, the snow continued to fall lightly.

Inside the car, their hands remained intertwined, neither of them pulling away as the road stretched ahead.

Between Years

Campus felt colder than it had before break.

Not just the air, though that had sharpened too. The trees stood bare against a flat winter sky, and patches of old snow clung stubbornly to the edges of sidewalks. Students filtered back slowly, dragging suitcases across brick paths, laughter echoing faintly between dorm buildings.

Liz stood outside her dorm for a moment before going in, adjusting the strap of her bag on her shoulder. The sapphire rested cool against her skin, catching pale light whenever she moved.

It felt like she had been gone longer than a week.

Inside, the hallway buzzed with returning voices and doors opening and closing. She pushed into her room just as Hannah nearly collided with her.

“You’re back!” Hannah shrieked, dropping her laundry basket.

Mia spun around from her desk chair. “Finally. We’ve been living off vending machine snacks and vibes.”

Liz laughed as they pulled her into a chaotic group hug.

“I was gone five days.”

“It was the longest five days of my life,” Hannah declared dramatically.

They sat on Liz’s bed almost immediately, bags forgotten.

“So,” Mia said, eyes narrowing playfully. “Tell us everything.”

Liz kicked off her boots and tucked her legs beneath her. “It was good. Really good.”

“That is not enough detail,” Hannah said. “We need scenes. Dialogue. Emotional breakthroughs.”

Liz shook her head, smiling.

She told them about the photo albums. About baking cookies. About the moonlit walk. She left out some of the quieter, heavier pieces, not because she wanted to hide them, but because they felt too personal to translate into dorm room storytelling.

When she mentioned the necklace, Hannah gasped.

“Show us again.”

Liz pulled it gently from beneath her sweater. The sapphire glinted under the dorm lights.

“Oh,” Mia breathed. “That is not casual.”

Hannah pointed at it accusingly. “That is I am serious about you jewelry.”

Liz rolled her eyes. “It’s just a necklace.”

“From his childhood bedroom Christmas,” Mia countered. “That is layered.”

Liz laughed, but heat crept up her neck.

“You also met his family,” Hannah reminded her. “This is escalating.”

“It’s not escalating,” Liz said quickly. Then paused. “It’s just… growing.”

Her roommates exchanged a look that was softer now.

“Well,” Mia said gently, “you look happy.”

Liz touched the sapphire again without thinking.

“I am.”

The first week back moved quickly.

Classes resumed. Syllabi were handed out. Professors launched into spring expectations like winter break had been a rumor.

Jayce seemed different in a subtle way.

Not distant.

Just focused.

Liz noticed it first in the way he checked his phone more often. Then in the way he carried his laptop everywhere, even to places he normally wouldn't. His notebook was fuller. His pen moved constantly.

One afternoon, she met him outside the library.

"Coffee?" she asked, nudging his shoulder.

He smiled immediately. "Always."

They made it halfway across the quad before his phone buzzed.

He glanced down at it.

"Sorry," he murmured, already reading.

She waited.

His expression shifted slightly. Concentrated.

"It's the small press that picked up my first book," he said, almost disbelieving. "They want to schedule a call."

Liz's eyebrows lifted. "That's good, right?"

"Yeah. Yeah, it is."

"Then answer."

He hesitated. "We were getting coffee."

"We can get coffee after."

He studied her face for any sign of disappointment.

She smiled easily. "Go."

He squeezed her hand once before stepping aside to take the call.

Liz stood there, watching him pace slightly as he talked. His voice shifted into something more measured. More professional. More careful.

She felt pride first.

Then something else she could not quite name.

He rejoined her ten minutes later, slightly breathless.

“They’re seeing a spike in sales again,” he said. “Apparently over break it picked up.”

“That’s amazing.”

“It’s weird,” he admitted. “I didn’t expect it.”

They still got coffee.

They still laughed.

But when he glanced at his phone again halfway through her story about Hannah’s failed attempt at reorganizing the closet, something small tugged at her chest.

She ignored it.

Two days later, they planned to meet between classes.

She arrived first, sitting at their usual table near the student center window. Ten minutes passed. Then fifteen.

Her phone buzzed.

Jayce: I’m so sorry. Professor kept me after class about something. Rain check?

She stared at the message for a moment.

It made sense. It was reasonable.

Liz: It’s okay. Don’t worry about it.

Three dots appeared. Then disappeared. Then appeared again.

Jayce: I’ll make it up to you.

She smiled faintly at her screen.

It’s fine, she told herself.

It was fine.

Later that evening, she sat cross legged on her bed with his first book open in her lap.

She had read pieces before, but now she moved slower. More intentionally.

The protagonist felt more familiar than she remembered.

The fear of not being enough. The constant internal pressure. The way he described silence as something loud.

Her fingers paused on a paragraph.

It felt too specific to be entirely fiction.

She read a scene where the main character stood in a kitchen late at night, arguing quietly with a parent who did not understand why writing mattered so much.

Liz swallowed.

She had never asked Jayce about that.

She turned the page.

There was a chapter about losing a friend over ambition. About choosing work over presence. About regret that lingered long after success.

Her chest tightened.

Was that imagined?

Or remembered?

She closed the book slowly.

Her phone sat beside her. She picked it up. Typed his name.

Then stopped.

She did not want to turn his work into interrogation.

If he wanted to tell her, he would.

Still, the questions lingered.

That night, they met in the library to study.

The space buzzed with low murmurs and rustling pages. Snow tapped softly against the tall windows.

Jayce sat across from her at first, laptop open, fingers moving quickly over the keyboard. He looked focused. Driven.

But not unreachable.

After a while, he moved to sit beside her instead.

They worked in comfortable silence.

At one point, he leaned back in his chair and exhaled.

“You okay?” she asked quietly.

“Yeah,” he said. “Just thinking.”

“About?”

“Deadlines. Chapters. All of it.”

She nodded.

Without looking up from his screen, he reached over and found her hand.

It was automatic. Unthinking.

His fingers laced with hers gently.

She looked down at their joined hands, then at him.

He was still typing with his other hand, brow slightly furrowed in concentration.

The connection was still there.

Just… adjusting.

She squeezed his hand lightly.

He squeezed back.

Outside, snow continued to fall between semesters, between holidays, between who they had been and who they were becoming.

Inside the quiet library, they sat shoulder to shoulder, learning how to move forward without letting go.

What We’re Becoming

The question followed her for two days before she finally asked it.

It lingered in the margins of her notebook while she tried to focus on lectures. It drifted back when she reread passages from his book late at night. It sat between them in small pauses, not heavy enough to break anything, but present.

They were in his dorm room when she finally spoke.

Snow dusted the outside of the window again, thin and restless. Jayce sat at his desk, laptop open but untouched for once. Liz was on his bed, curled against the pillows with his first book resting open in her lap.

He glanced over at her.

“You’ve been on the same page for five minutes.”

She looked up slowly.

“Can I ask you something?”

He turned his chair fully toward her. “You can ask me anything.”

She closed the book carefully, marking the page with her thumb.

“How much of this is real?”

He stilled.

Not defensive. Just thoughtful.

“That depends,” he said quietly. “Which part?”

She hesitated. “The kitchen scene. The argument about writing not being practical. The friend who drifted away. The fear that if you chase something too hard, you’ll lose everything else.”

He leaned back slightly, exhaling through his nose.

“Some of it happened,” he admitted. “Some of it didn’t.”

“That’s not an answer.”

A faint smile touched his mouth. “It’s the only honest one.”

She waited.

“The argument in the kitchen,” he said after a moment, “was real. Not word for word. But the feeling was.”

“With your parents?”

“With my dad,” he said. “He didn’t get why I would risk something stable for something uncertain. He wasn’t cruel about it. Just practical. And I took it harder than I should have.”

Liz absorbed that quietly.

“And the friend?”

He looked down at his hands.

“That was exaggerated,” he said. “But not entirely fictional. There was someone who stopped calling when I got busy. Or maybe I stopped calling first. I’m still not sure.”

She felt something tighten in her chest.

“And the fear?” she asked gently.

He looked at her then. Fully.

“That’s all real.”

The room felt smaller.

“I don’t write about losing success,” he said slowly. “I write about losing people. That’s the part that scares me.”

Liz swallowed.

“Not failing?” she asked.

“Failing would suck,” he admitted. “But failing alone would be worse.”

The honesty in his voice was steady. Not dramatic. Not exaggerated. Just true.

She shifted closer on the bed.

“I didn’t want to assume anything,” she said. “Reading it felt like… peeking into something private.”

“It is,” he said. “But you’re allowed there.”

That did something quiet to her heartbeat.

There was a pause.

Then he asked it.

“What do you see for next year?”

She blinked. “Next year?”

“Not forever,” he clarified quickly. “Not big life plan stuff. Just… next year.”

She leaned back against the wall, thinking.

“Spring semester,” she said slowly. “Surviving my course load. Maybe applying for that internship downtown.”

He nodded. “You’d be good at that.”

“Maybe,” she said with a small smile. “Summer, I was thinking about staying on campus. Working. Saving.”

“For your program abroad?” he asked.

She looked surprised. “You remembered.”

“Of course I did.”

She studied him for a second.

“What about you?” she asked.

He rubbed a hand over the back of his neck.

“Finishing this draft,” he said. “Seeing what happens with the press. Maybe submitting to a bigger one this time.”

“That’s huge.”

“It could be nothing,” he countered.

“It could be something,” she said.

Silence settled again, but it wasn’t uncomfortable.

He leaned forward, elbows on his knees.

“Do you ever worry,” he asked carefully, “that this will get complicated?”

She didn’t pretend not to understand.

“You mean if your career takes off?”

He nodded.

She looked down at her hands.

“Yeah,” she admitted.

He didn’t interrupt.

“I’m scared of being left behind,” she said. “Not because you’d want to leave. But because ambition moves fast. And sometimes people who aren’t moving at the same speed get… lost.”

The vulnerability in her voice felt raw in a way she rarely let it be.

Jayce stood and crossed the small space between them.

He knelt in front of her, hands resting gently on her knees.

“I don’t want success if there’s no one to share it with,” he said quietly.

She searched his face for exaggeration. She didn’t find it.

“I don’t want to build something alone,” he continued. “What’s the point of achieving everything if you look up and there’s no one there to tell about it?”

Her throat tightened.

“I’m not asking you to slow down for me,” she said.

“And I’m not asking you to wait for me,” he replied.

They held each other’s gaze.

“I just don’t want us to drift,” she whispered.

“We won’t,” he said.

“You can’t promise that.”

“No,” he agreed. “But I can promise I’ll fight it if it starts happening.”

Her breath hitched slightly.

He reached up and brushed a strand of hair behind her ear. His fingers lingered against her cheek.

“We talk,” he said. “We adjust. We show up.”

She nodded slowly.

“Okay.”

He leaned forward then, pressing his forehead gently against hers.

No rush.

No fireworks.

Just warmth.

Their hands intertwined between them, fingers fitting easily together. She closed her eyes. So did he.

For a moment, the world outside that small dorm room didn’t matter. Not deadlines. Not expectations. Not distance. Not fear.

Just this.

He pulled her into him then, wrapping his arms around her fully. She melted into the hug, her face tucked against his shoulder, his chin resting in her hair.

They stayed like that longer than necessary.

Long enough for doubt to quiet.

Long enough for something steadier to take root.

When they finally pulled back, she looked up at him.

“What are you doing for New Year’s?” he asked softly.

She raised an eyebrow. “Avoiding overcrowded parties and bad decisions.”

He smiled. “Good.”

“Why?”

“Because I don’t want a party,” he said. “I want… something quieter.”

She tilted her head. “Just us?”

“Just us.”

Her smile came slowly. “I’d like that.”

He squeezed her hands gently.

“Then it’s a plan.”

Outside, snow brushed lightly against the window again.

Inside, they sat close, grounded in something that felt less like a whirlwind and more like a choice.

Not dramatic.

Not loud.

Just intentional.

And as the year inched toward its final days, they leaned into what they were becoming.



Midnight

Snow had started again sometime before noon.

Not the violent kind that tore sideways in the wind, but the quiet kind. The kind that softened edges and swallowed noise. Campus felt muted beneath it, as if the world had been wrapped in cotton. Paths turned pale. Rooftops gathered white along their seams. Bare branches carried delicate frost like glasswork.

The last day of the year always unsettled Liz. It felt like standing in a doorway with one hand still on the frame, unsure which room counted as home.

In her dorm room, Hannah had claimed the mirror like territory.

“No. Absolutely not,” Hannah said, tugging a sweater from Liz’s hands. “You are not dressing like you’re going to a study group. It’s New Year’s Eve.”

Mia didn’t even look up from her phone. “Jayce is going to short-circuit if she shows up like that.”

Liz rolled her eyes, but her fingers trembled slightly as she reached for the necklace resting on her desk. The one he’d given her at Christmas. She fastened it carefully. The small pendant caught the gray light from the window and held it.

Hannah’s voice softened. “Okay. That’s unfair.”

Mia smiled. “You look different.”

Liz paused. “Different how?”

“Happy.”

The word settled in her chest.

Not anxious.
Not bracing.
Happy.

Her phone buzzed.

On my way. Don’t laugh. I’m weirdly nervous.

Her mouth curved before she could stop it.

Why are you nervous?

Because this feels important.

Her pulse steadied instead of racing.

Across campus, Jayce stood in front of his own mirror for longer than he'd admit. He adjusted his jacket again, then stilled his hands. Clean lines. Dark coat. Nothing dramatic. Intentional without trying too hard.

He rarely cared this much about how he looked.

Tonight felt like a marker. Not because of fireworks or countdowns. Because it felt like a line between who he'd been and who he was trying to grow into.

He grabbed his keys and stepped into the cold.

They met at the rooftop of the old academic building, the one technically off-limits and universally ignored. It overlooked the campus and beyond that the town lights stretching into the dark horizon. They'd come here after finals once. Talked until sunrise without noticing time passing.

Liz reached the top stair just as he opened the door from the other side.

They both stopped.

It was absurd how a glance could still feel new.

Snow clung to her hair in fragile crystals. The necklace rested at her collarbone. She looked softer in the cold light. Stronger too.

"You look…" he began, then exhaled. "I don't have the right word."

"Good," she said. "I didn't want you rehearsing one."

He stepped closer and brushed a snowflake from her cheek with his thumb. "You're shaking."

"It's cold."

“Liar.”

She smiled. “Okay. A little.”

They moved toward the railing. Someone had left fairy lights strung along it weeks ago. They still glowed faintly, small pockets of gold against the white.

Below them, the town hummed. Distant music. Laughter carried thinly upward. A test firework flared early, a brief bloom of color against the deepening sky.

They let the quiet stretch.

“So,” he said, leaning against the railing. “First time we met.”

Liz groaned. “Don’t.”

“You almost spilled coffee on my journal.”

“You put your journal next to my coffee.”

“You said, ‘Wow. You look like you needed that.’”

She covered her face. “I was panicking.”

“You were honest.”

“That’s not better.”

He laughed softly. “I thought you were intimidating.”

Her head snapped toward him. “What?”

“You looked like you saw straight through me.”

“I was terrified of you.”

“I was trying not to stare.”

Silence.

“You were?” she asked quietly.

“Yeah.”

The word carried more weight than it should have.

Memories unfolded between them without effort. The disastrous study session that turned into a three hour argument about a novel neither of them even liked. The night he’d admitted he was afraid his writing would never matter. The time he showed up with soup when she was sick and insisted it was “efficient time management.”

“Christmas,” she said softly.

“The walk,” he answered.

Moonlight on snow. Breath fogging in shared air. The first time neither of them pretended they were just friends.

“I didn’t expect this year to change anything,” he said after a moment. “I thought it would just be classes and deadlines. Me trying to outrun the version of myself I didn’t like.”

She studied him. “It changed everything.”

Snow fell heavier now, drifting between them, catching in lashes and coat sleeves. The sky deepened to navy. Town lights flickered like scattered constellations.

“I was so focused on becoming something,” he said. “I didn’t realize I could grow into it. With someone.”

Her throat tightened. “I was scared you’d outgrow this. Outgrow me.”

He shook his head immediately. “No.”

“People change,” she said. “Ambition changes people.”

“Maybe,” he replied. “But I don’t want to become someone who walks away from what matters.”

It wasn’t grand. It wasn’t poetic.

It was steady.

From below, someone shouted that there were ten minutes left.

They both laughed, nerves breaking the heaviness.

“Are we supposed to do something dramatic?” she asked.

“I think so.”

“Champagne?”

“I brought sparkling water.”

She laughed, bright and unguarded. “Of course you did.”

They stepped away from the edge as more students gathered below. The wind picked up slightly, brushing snow across the rooftop in soft spirals.

Five minutes.

A rough practice countdown rose from the lawn, uneven and chaotic.

Without looking at her, he reached for her hand.

She laced their fingers together immediately.

“Next year,” he said quietly. “Spring. Summer. I don’t know what it’s going to look like.”

“Me neither.”

“But I want you in it.”

Her breath hitched.

“Not because it’s easy,” he continued. “And not because it’s safe. Because when I picture moving forward… you’re there.”

She stepped into him until there was no space left between them. “Then we’ll figure it out,” she said. “Season by season.”

The real countdown began.

Ten.

The sound carried upward in waves.

Nine.

He turned fully toward her.

Eight.

Snow clung to her lashes.

Seven.

Her cheeks flushed pink from cold and feeling.

Six.

“I’m still nervous,” he admitted.

Five.

“Me too.”

Four.

“But not about us.”

Three.

His hand slid to her waist.

Two.

Her fingers curved along his jaw.

One.

Midnight.

Fireworks bloomed beyond the town in distant bursts of color. Cheers rose from below, scattered and bright.

Up on the rooftop, everything felt still.

He kissed her.

Not rushed. Not urgent. Just sure.

When they parted, their foreheads rested together, breath mingling in the cold.

“I want more years like this,” he said.

“Then we’ll build them,” she answered.

They stayed there long after the cheering faded. Watching light fracture against falling snow. Listening as celebration thinned into quiet.

No impossible promises.
No vows about forever.

Just warmth against winter. Fingers intertwined. Shoulders pressed close.

And when the year turned, they did not leap blindly into it.

They stepped forward. Together.